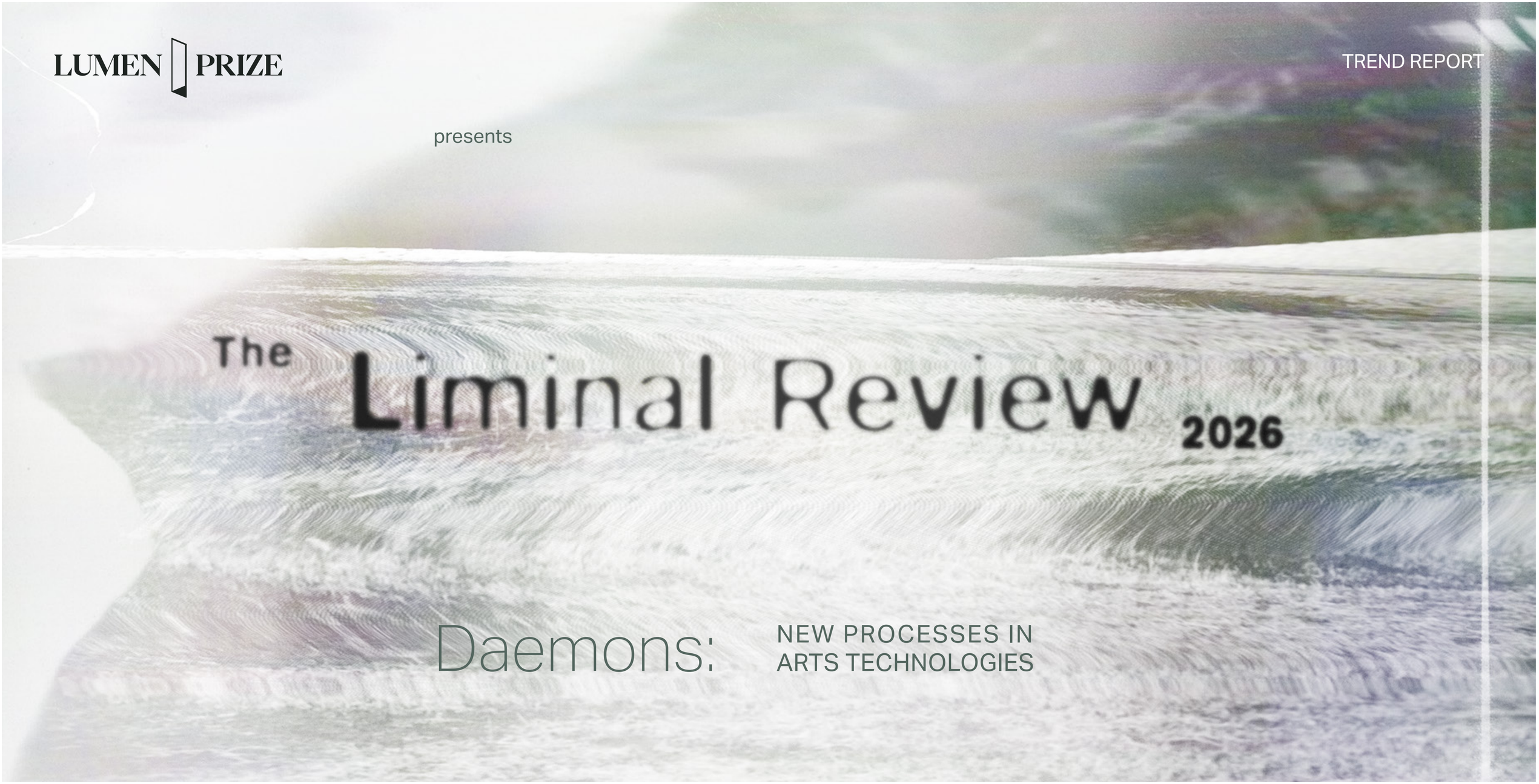
LUMEN PRIZE

TREND REPORT

presents

The Liminal Review 2026

Daemons: NEW PROCESSES IN ARTS TECHNOLOGIES



lumenprize.org

Written by:

DR. RACHEL FALCONER

Head of Creative Technology, Goldsmiths University London

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The Liminal Review 2026

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Author
Rachel Falconer, Goldsmiths

Development and Editing
Erin Thompson
Gillian Leitten

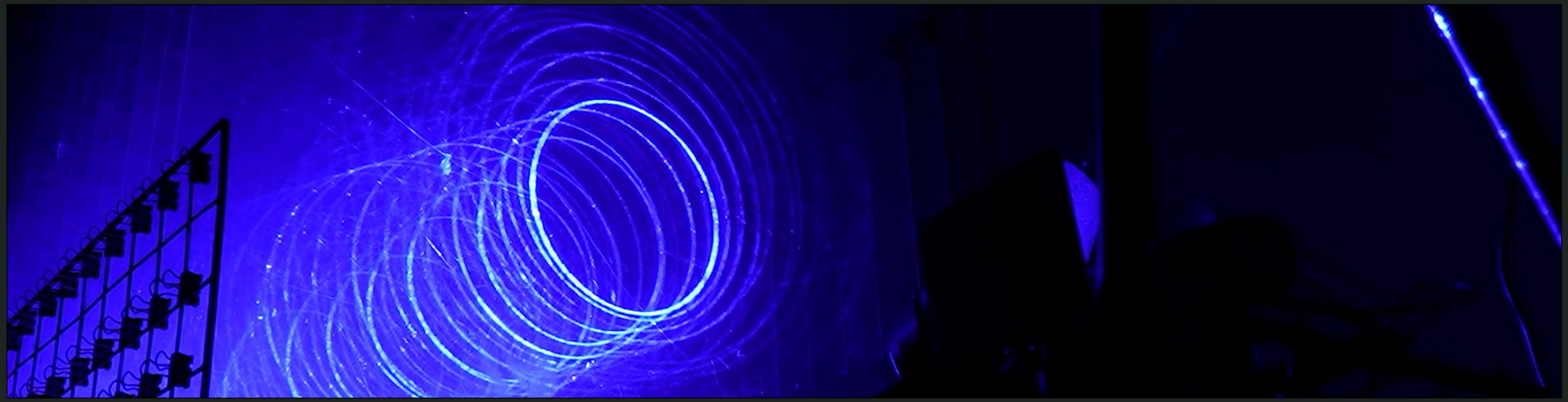
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Chi Zhang, *Blind Men Listening to the Sea*



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READING

The Liminal Review 2026



niceaunties, *Mirror Into Auntieverse*

Fifteen years ago, The Lumen Prize was founded on a simple belief: that artists working with technology help us understand what technological change actually means, often before the rest of us even have the language for it. This year, that belief still holds.

In 2026, 2,225 artists from 82 countries submitted work to The Lumen Prize. Nearly half of this year's applicants have spent more than a decade developing their practice as artists, a sign of how far the field has come. We've spent these same fifteen years working alongside them, wherever they are in their journey.

The Liminal Review 2026, again authored by Dr. Rachel Falconer, names this year's defining condition a Daemon: a process that runs continuously in the background, whether or not anyone is watching. Reading the Review, we found ourselves recognizing something more familiar than we expected. Falconer has written a report that doesn't just analyze this year's work from a distance. It reads like something closer to home, closer to how we're all actually living right now. Across thousands of individual submissions, she's traced a pattern, one many of us already feel, even if we hadn't yet found the words for it. Somewhere along the way, infrastructure arrived gradually enough that no single moment felt like a decision. And yet here we are, adjusting to systems we don't fully remember accepting. Did we choose this? And if not, what happens now?

The four Daemons traced in this year's Review, Thalassic Drift, Haptic Undertow, Palimpsest Sediment, and Jurisdictional Static, each locate that unease in a different register. Water, once a metaphor for flow and possibility, becomes something more literal, the shared infrastructure linking a data center's coolant to a glacier's slow disappearance. The body, increasingly mediated and anonymized online, becomes a site where artists insist on presence rather than accepting disappearance. The archive, long imagined as a fixed record, turns out to depend on constant choices about what's kept, what's edited, and what's allowed to fade, choices artists this year are claiming for themselves. The systems that now scrape, negotiate, and act without human permission are read as continuous with older, more familiar structures of control, ones we have lived inside for far longer than we'd like to admit.

We don't read this year's Review as pessimistic, though it is, by design, less resolved than last year's. Where 2025's artists worked through crisis toward repair, 2026's artists are doing something quieter and, in its way, more demanding. They hold space for genuine ambiguity, refuse easy closure, and ask us to sit with questions about consent, agency, and who or what is actually in control. These questions don't yet have tidy answers. Artists have always held up a mirror to help us see our own moment clearly. This year, that mirror feels less fixed than usual, reflecting not only the systems watching us, but the possibility that we've become the mirror ourselves.

As we look toward our sixteenth year, this is precisely the work we exist to support: championing artists, and building the relationships, credibility, and infrastructure that let their insight shape how the rest of us understand our world and how it's changing. This year, that insight starts with the right questions, and artists in our community are asking them pointedly.

We extend our deepest gratitude to Dr. Rachel Falconer, whose clarity and rigor shaped this Review from its first page to its last. Thank you to our International Selectors Committee for the care and expertise they brought to every conversation behind it. And thank you to our partners at Onassis ONX for their ongoing collaboration and support. And, as always, we thank the global community of artists whose work makes visible what the rest of us are only beginning to notice. Their work is the reason this Review exists, and the reason Lumen does too.

Gillian Leitten
Executive Director, The Lumen Prize

and

Erin Thompson
Chief Creative Officer, The Lumen Prize

FROM ONASSIS ONX

Algo as Pain

Etymologically, the word algorithm is unrelated to ἄλγος (álgos), meaning pain. It derives instead from the name of the 9th century Persian mathematician Muḥammad ibn Mūsā al Khwārizmī. And yet, in a deeply ironic fashion, algorithms are inexorably intertwined with pain.

I fail to rationally account for the association.
Still, I am convinced of its existence.

It may be because of the way in which we humans encounter algorithmic manifestations in what constitutes our world: through social media, through generative AI systems, through a myriad of otherwise inconspicuous devices in which they are embedded. They form an unseen, yet omnipresent nexus. It is fundamentally alien to our existence, and yet so uncannily humanesque.

It is this omnipresence that marks the impossibility of meaningfully discussing or representing algorithmic reality. It is its invisibility that marks its invincibility.

When the realm of the digital could be clearly demarcated and distinguished from that of the analogue, digital art could meaningfully exist. The collapse of the two worlds into one constitutes digital art's dissolution. Hence the resurgence of the analogue, the disconnected, the non-algorithmic.

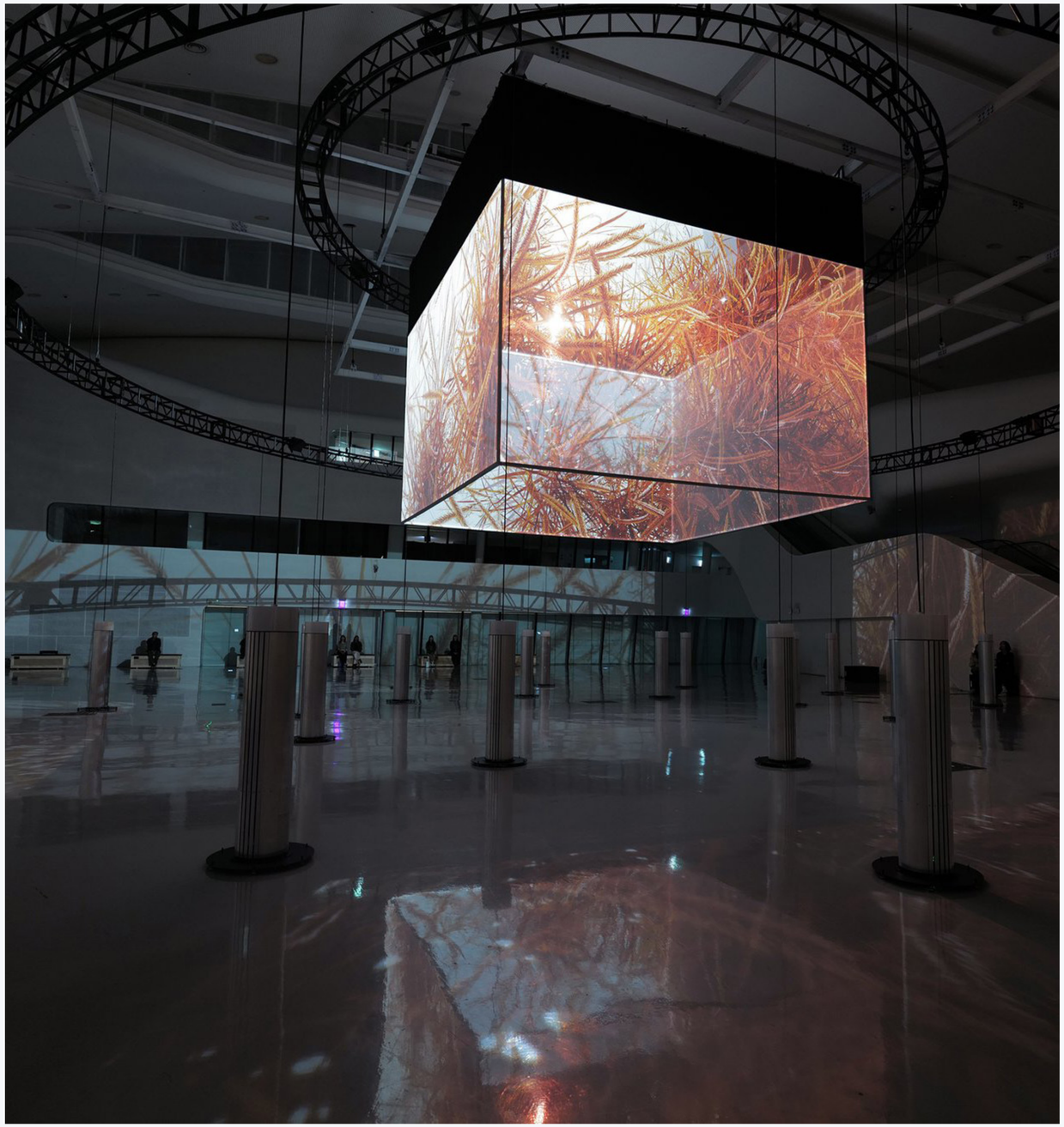
We are currently experiencing it not just in arts and culture, but also in media devices and in the means of creative production and consumption. This is not a return to a pre-digital or pre-algorithmic condition. It is the direct product of an all-encompassing algo-reality, a state of exception on which the rule of the algorithm is founded.

In the same manner, the untamable body, the messy performance, the unclassified media claim their position in the territory of the digital. Time-based digital artworks, human and physical AI performances, combinations of immersive theatre with XR pieces, social media and algorithmically mediated performance lectures are but a few examples. In all of them, digital and immersive art seek forms of expression that reflect the continuum of an analogue-digital world.

As the real fails to find refuge in the safety of photographic fixation, the meaning of the image fundamentally changes. The image passes gradually from documentation of reality, or expression of human creativity, to the logic of the operative image. This passage pushes artistic research towards questions about the boundaries of human perception, even in neuroscientific terms. At other moments, it begs for techno-spirituality, algo-shamanism and the restitution of the ritual as a dominant immersive practice.



Luke Shannon, *Replacement Character plotter-scanner*



Yinyung Kang, *Light Architecture*

Algorithms contain pain because, like our children, they make us face our choices. Painful as this may be, it should not be a cause for inaction.

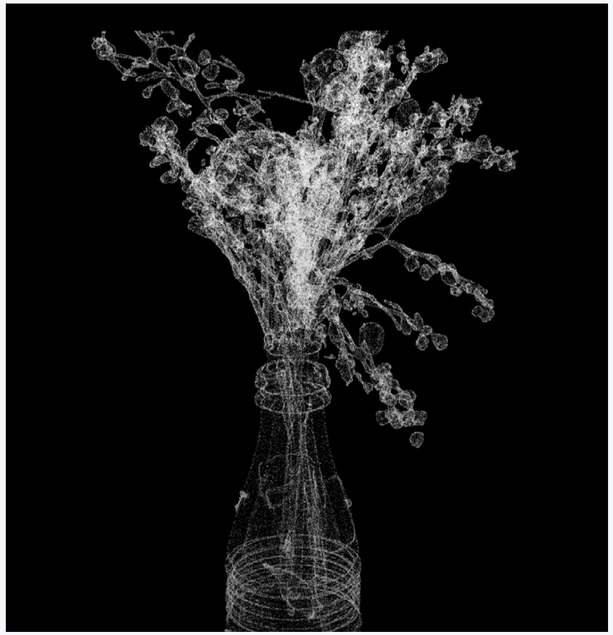
Onassis ONX began as an attempt to inhabit this contradiction. It is a place where artists work with frontier technologies without owing anyone a demonstration of them, and where the work is allowed to remain unfinished, unclassifiable or simply wrong. What that practice keeps teaching us has more to do with álgos than with innovation. Protected time has proven to be our scarcest resource. The pieces that matter are usually the ones no department knows how to programme. And the institutional question that keeps returning is one of tolerance: how much uncertainty or pain can an organisation carry on behalf of the artists it hosts?

We are in dire need of new forms of institutions: ones that retain the artist at the center while remaining deeply engaged with frontier technologies; ones that have the financial and curatorial freedom to experiment and to fail, again and again; ones that can remain unapologetically human-centric in a post-human world.

Prodromos Tsiavos
Head of Digital Development and
Innovation, Onassis Foundation

Foreword

Reflecting back on this year at the nexus of art and technology, there is a palpable, vertiginous drop: a shift from communities of creative practice long engaged with advanced technologies as tools and objects of transmission, towards an acute acknowledgment and critical observation of the agentic role these technologies now inhabit within networked practices themselves.



Constance Lu and Tianying Lei, *Entropy of Belonging*

2026 marked a probing, infrastructural turn in the relational dynamics between artists and the technologies they work with. Where the inaugural edition of this Review interrogated the critical reach of these tools and methodologies by artists – what worlds they could render, the critical registers they held or synthesised – this year's 2,225 submissions from 82 countries surface a sharp and expansive apparatus of frictions. Arts practices placed in dialogue with advanced and networked creative strategies have pivoted at large to investigate and challenge not only the sovereignty of structures of autonomous agents, but also the soft boundary points at which governance itself becomes ambiguous, generative, and compelled to isolate logics of decision-making and responsibility across iterative nodes of creative practice operating within institutional and economic ecologies. Across Lumen's three categories: Legacy Futures, Systems & Structures, and Experiential Innovation, a notable shift emerges in creative practice, from treating technology as a subject of aesthetic interrogation, or as potential accomplice and disruptor, towards its constitution as infrastructure itself: something to be governed, inherited, metabolised, and held accountable.

The second edition of *The Liminal Review* moves away from the trend spotting device and thematic framing of Signal, and, in its place, we encounter the Daemon for the first time. Daemon denotes a background computational process that runs silently, without being prompted, continuing to execute, sense, and operate whether or not anyone is watching the terminal. It is, I think, a perfect cognitive model to adopt for a silent oracle and observational guide for a year in which so much of the most compelling work being produced lends conceptual focus to agency exercised without permission, embargoed or corrupted memory stores, systems that increasingly act upon us in movements of renegade systemic ontological classification, distributed economies of care (or otherwise), all in stealth modes of motion, operating beneath the surface.

I would like to extend my profound gratitude to the incredible Lumen team for the continued invitation to author this report for the second year running; to the International Selectors Committee for the expertise and generosity of spirit that gives this Review its multi-perspectival, textured layers of reading; and to partners at Onassis ONX. Above all, my thanks go to the global community of artists who continue, submission after submission, to sharpen our sense of what this particular moment in arts practice challenges and signifies, as the work continues to evolve and meet the world on its own terms: boundary-crossing, interrogative, critically enmeshed, and porous to the reactive, responsive, seismic complexities at stake.

INTRODUCTION:
From Signal to Daemon

If 2025's Signals sought fixed points from which to read the field, 2026's Daemons gesture instead towards something closer to what recent hydrofeminist thought – following Astrida Neimanis's reconception of bodies as bodies of water[1] – might call a logic of circulation rather than containment: practice less as a bounded territory than as a membrane, porous and in motion, exchanging with what moves through it.

Where the 2025 edition of *The Liminal Review* organised its critical apparatus around three Signals – Synthetic Trauma and the Poetics of Erasure, Techno-Spiritualism and Digital Animism, and Anarchival Re-renderings – the *2026 Liminal Review* replaces Signal with Daemon. This substitution is not a rebrand; it is a conscious pivot, a response to a rapidly changing field over the last twelve months. The shift is made at the level of terminology and curatorial framing because this is where such changes first become visible, tangible, and salient.



Chloé Lee, *Reflections of Little Red Dot*

A Daemon, in computational usage, is a background process: one that runs continuously, self-initiating, executing without a user's direct invocation, indifferent to whether anyone is present to witness its execution.

This is the chosen register for a year in which the works under review are themselves increasingly authored by processes that act without being asked: scraping, sorting, minting, classifying, distributing, and occasionally deceiving, on a loop, unattended, and unsupervised. Where a signal is broadcast and received, implying sender, message, and an audience assembled to decode it, a Daemon simply operates. It does not wait for uptake. It does not require a witness to justify its continuation. The four Daemons that structure this year's Review are not sections in the classic editorial sense, arranged for the reader's convenience, but instead, activate processes, probing in sleuth mode through 2,225 submissions, surfacing patterns the applicant data alone, however rigorously tabulated, could never have shown on its own.

[1] Astrida Neimanis, *Bodies of Water: Posthuman Feminist Phenomenology* (London: Bloomsbury Academic, 2017).

The shift is not cosmetic, or conceived as curatorial vanity, but is poised to track a tangible, measurable change in the entries received across this year's 122-day open call, drawn from 82 countries – seeing a 15.5% increase in geographic representation over 2025, arriving from a pool that is more mature, increasingly established, and professionally embedded than in previous years: 66.9% of applicants fall between 30 and 49, and nearly half report more than eleven years working in the art and technology space. This is no longer, and perhaps never accurately was, a field of experimental testing, surface-level memetic aesthetic indulgence, or expanded digital studio practice. We now bear witness to a community of mid-career practitioners, globally distributed, economically recognised, and frequently mutating across increasingly less ossified disciplines, who subsume, interpolate, and stochastically render methodologies and relational dynamics in close and critical dialogue with advanced technologies as they are assimilated and disappear into the practice itself.

Over the last twelve months, four emergent tendencies have crystallised as reflective beacons for the field, recurring across Lumen Prize categories and wider ecologies of practice with a persistence and pattern-legibility that has compelled the Review to be organised around them.



sister sylvester, *Constantinopoliad*

Sarah Meyohas, *Phase Transition*



Artists are thinking with and through bodies of water as both subject and critical infrastructure, engaging in an entwined and entangled dynamic with the hidden hydrologies of the data centre as much as the temporally charged retreat of the glacier. Here, the ocean acts as fluvial archive, as circulatory coolant, as littoral memory, and as extractively claimed, offshore entity. Creative practitioners are insistently returning to the body politic.

Haptically infused, sensor-driven work holds the complexities of fleshy friction and corporal weight, a form of resistance to an attention economy that is insistent that bodies stay legible, quantifiable, and conveniently distributed. Artists are emerging as archivists and stewards of memory. Memory here refuses the register of saccharine nostalgia, reconstituted instead as an active, contested, and frequently adversarial site of recall. The archive itself becomes something to be hacked, embroidered, reauthored, or refused. Water, body, and archive are shadowed by a fourth condition: artists building with and foregrounding AI agents that act autonomously in the world – posting, minting, deceiving, negotiating, and distributing care or withholding it, unauthored and unauthorised.

These four tendencies became Daemon 01 through 04: Thalassic Drift, Haptic Undertow, Palimpsest Sediment, and Jurisdictional Static. These are not neutral categories: partial and positioned, by design. They are, like last year's Signals before them, a curatorial argument and positioning that speaks to where the field is heading. However, these are not intended as categories that authoritatively define, but rather act as nodes of critical discourse, landed upon through a foraging and gathering, a culmination of relational contingencies. Read together, they trace a movement away from technology as a tool that artists have instrumentalised, subordinated, and controlled, to technology as a condition an artist morally inhabits, responsibly negotiates through, and is challenged and unsettled by. If 2025 asked how artists were working through crisis in dialogue with technology, 2026 is primed to interrogate what it means to operate creatively within a condition of crisis that has receded into infrastructure – distributed, unwitnessed, running quietly in stealth mode. Here the conditions of practice in the hybrid art-technology space are not exceptional, but operational.



Ryuta Aoki, *Alternative Computations — Worlds Otherwise Calculated*

01

Thalassic Drift

WATER AS INFRASTRUCTURE, ARCHIVE, AND UNCONSCIOUS

DAEMON 01:

Thalassic Drift

Water surfaces across an estimated 42% of this year's submissions. Refusing reduction to ecological allegory, it manifests as the hidden coolant of the AI data centre, humming behind a wall few visitors ever see; as the historical record locked in a retreating glacier, a library checking itself out one melt-season at a time; as ecological cameo and reluctant collaborator, a recurring metaphor for memory, flux, and the unconscious.



Theo Triantafyllidis, *Drift Lattice*

Water is not invented by the newest infrastructures, only reactivated. Where 2025's ecological work tended toward documentation, with the motivation of making visible what was already in the process of being lost, 2026's aqueous submissions are incrementally relational. This year, artists are positioning themselves less as witnesses to hydric phenomena than as correspondents in dialogue, answerable, and occasionally overruled. This is not simply an aesthetic pull towards the maritime, but an active tracking and pronounced theoretical current gestured towards in this Review's introduction: Neimanis's hydrofeminist refusal of the bounded, discrete body in favour of bodies understood as literally, materially continuous with the water that moves through and around them. The works gathered in this Daemon extend that refusal outwards, from the body to infrastructure, treating the data centre's cooling system and the glacier's melt cycle as different registers of the same wet, entangled condition, rather than as discreet entities or polar opposites, positioned as natural or synthetic, to be kept artificially sectioned and apart.

Thalassic Drift tracks work with cognitive currents rather than lines, in tidal flows rather than linear timelines. Against a field still largely gridded by Cartesian logic, a logic that seeks to consolidate culturally discrete objects with traceable provenance and closed systems of value, water offers another model of intelligence entirely: one that leaks, pools, seeps under the foundations, and categorically refuses containment. Agency here is current, not command.

One of the clearest articulations of this Daemon is seen in Theo Triantafyllidis's *Drift Lattice* (2025). Consisting of a live simulation in which a marine ecosystem of crabs, fish, diving birds, and autonomous cleanup drones, working the currents against tangles of seaweed and discarded plastics, is driven by real-time data extracted from global climate monitoring networks and oceanic research programs. As environmental stressors intensify and are revealed in the underlying data, Triantafyllidis's simulation shifts between a kind of fragile equilibrium and pronounced cascading decline, refusing viewers the stability of a finished pictorial plane. *Drift Lattice* signals an expansion of Triantafyllidis's earlier work *BugSim* (Pheromone Spa, 2022), a lush terrarium ecosystem of ants and bees simulating environmental repair at microscopic scale, and builds out to an oceanic register – trading the closed circuit of the terrarium for the open world system of the ocean, which responds to climate data as it unfolds before us. Drawing on James Bridle's *Ways of Being*[2] and Holly Jean Buck's *After Geoengineering*[3], the piece entangles human, artificial, and natural intelligence into a single interdependent web, refusing the common impulse to set them against each other and gesturing toward large-scale interventions, Buck's kelp farms for carbon capture among them, as a speculative response to real ecological crisis. What makes *Drift Lattice* a Thalassic Drift case study rather than simply an ecological frieze is its responsiveness: this is not a diorama of collapse but a live barometer, its state changing hour to hour with the data that feeds it. Where *Drift Lattice* engages with logics and simulations of collapse, Dotdotdot's *Sea Oasis – Survival Architecture* takes intervention to the point of submersion. Developed with

[2]James Bridle, *Ways of Being: Animals, Plants, Machines: The Search for a Planetary Intelligence* (London: Allen Lane, 2022).

[3]Holly Jean Buck, *After Geoengineering: Climate Tragedy, Repair, and Restoration* (London: Verso, 2019).



Theo Triantafyllidis, *Drift Lattice*



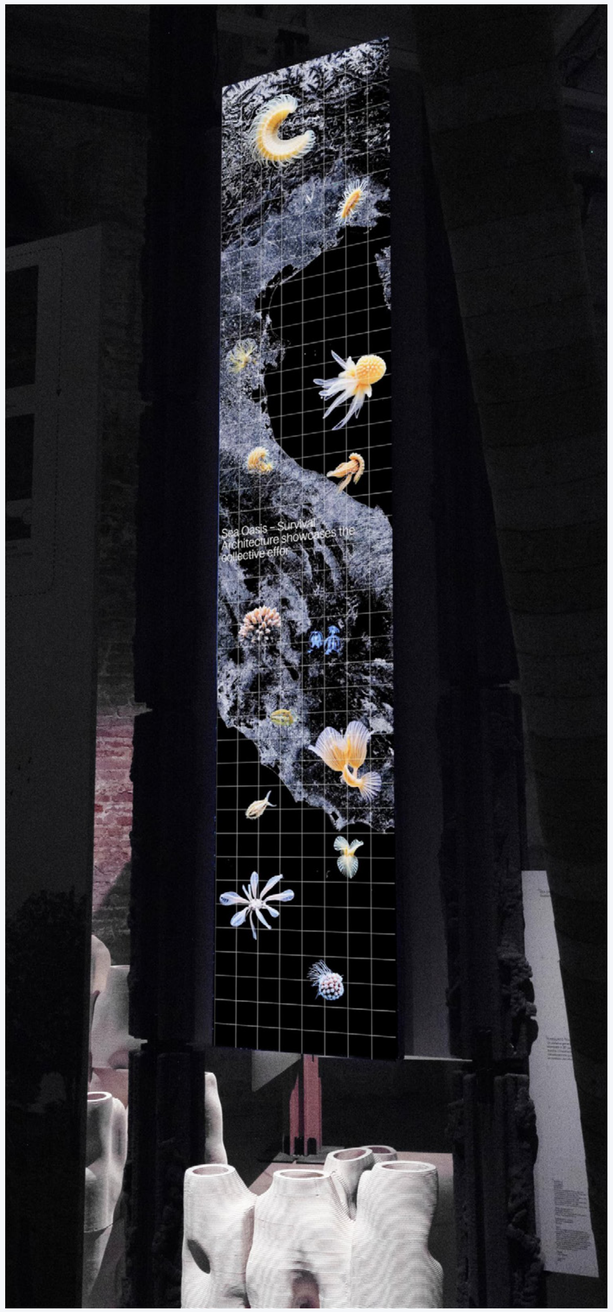
Dotdotdot, *Sea Oasis - Survival Architecture*



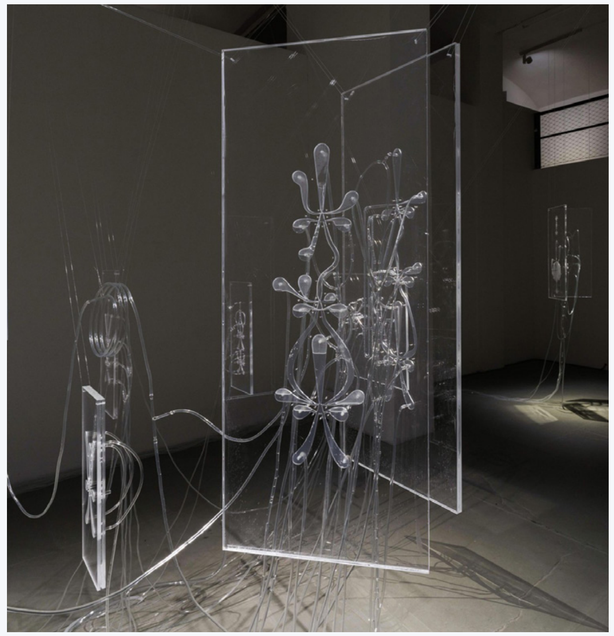
Dotdotdot, *Sea Oasis - Survival Architecture*

marine restoration researchers at the University of Padua and presented at the 2025 Venice Architecture Biennale under Carlo Ratti's curatorship, the installation envelops visitors in intricate 3D-printed reef structures, algorithmically designed to take cues from biological "ecosystem engineers" such as oysters, organisms that construct their own subaquatic architectures as systems of life aggregation. In the piece, a soundscape merges underwater biophonies with digital harmonics, while a dynamic video interface visualises, in real time, the AI's own decision-making logic as it processes environmental parameters (temperature, pH, salinity), biological dynamics (predation, reproduction, competition), and anthropogenic pressures (fishing, chemical, noise, and light pollution) to determine the precise coordinates at which the reefs should be submerged for maximum restoration impact. Crucially, the governing logic is explicitly regenerative rather than illustrative. The structures shown at the Biennale were never destined for storage and were conserved and absorbed into a living ecological system that continues past the exhibition's Finissage. This is future marine infrastructure, birthed at the Biennale, not staged by it. The structures are now located on the floor of the North Adriatic at the coordinates the AI collaborator selected, and their effect on marine biodiversity is being tracked as the subject of two ongoing doctoral theses. Positioned in critical dialogue with *Drift Lattice*, *Sea Oasis* pushes this Daemon's argument past simulation and into direct, accountable consequence. The same real-time environmental data driving the virtual ecosystem also determines the coordinates of the reefs themselves. The gallery visitor's encounter with "art" does not conclude at the threshold of institutional walls but continues on the sea floor, months after the exhibition closes: evolving, unwitnessed, unfinished.

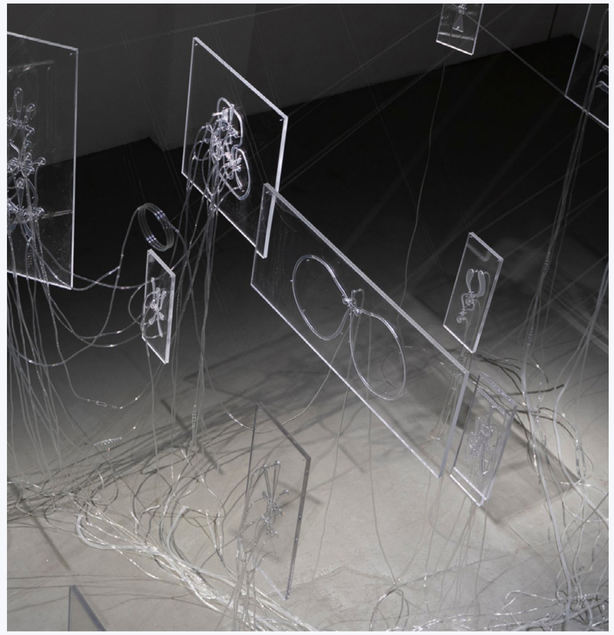
A third work turns the Daemon's framing toward a different register: past metaphor and infrastructure, into computation itself. Ioana Vreme Moser's *Fluid Anatomy* consists of an analogue hydro-pneumatic computer generated by water and air instead of electricity. The installation is created through the meticulous restoration and milling of over twenty fluidic circuit forms in transparent acrylic recovered from 1950s and '60s patents and archives. These structures belong to fluidics, a discipline that briefly rivalled electronics as a computational paradigm, whereby fluid jets



Dotdotdot, *Sea Oasis - Survival Architecture*



Ioana Vreme Moser, *Fluid Anatomy 1*







Antigoni Tsagkaropoulou, *In The Wild*

Antigoni Tsagkaropoulou, *In The Wild*



perform operations equivalent to transistors, deployed for their resistance to radiation in spacecraft and heart valves. Throughout *Fluid Anatomy*, water courses through a branching network of tubes and "fluidistors," or fluidic transistors that count, store, compare, subtract, and sum, regulated and tracked by a large oscillator and observed through fluidic sensors that trace presence on a parallel air circuit. Fluidic oscillators channel spoken verse into cascaded tones, rendering the machine's calculations sonic as well as visible. Adopting fluidics as a road less travelled and teasing out an alternative future to electronics, the work proposes a counterpoint to accelerated, obscured computational mechanisms hidden inside the black box, and instead renders its innate processes visible, transparent, resonant, and tuned into the rhythms of water moving through a tube.

Another work returns the Daemon from the computer back to the wetland it was modelled on. Antigoni Tsagkaropoulou's *In The Wild* premiered at the 9th Thessaloniki Biennale as an eighteen-minute film presented inside a seventeen-metre constructed wetland ecosystem consisting of two ponds, reed and water-lily planting sourced from a nursery dedicated to resilient aquatic species. Visitors walk through red clay paths to reach the screen, the approach inviting a cosy point of entry and a nesting of the visitor into the space, rather than a simply detached viewing. The film was shot in a robotics laboratory and on location across three wetlands in Greece and Los Angeles, mixing 16mm footage from a vintage Krasnogorsk camera with digital video, incorporating archival material, poetry, and first person footage recorded through the body camera of a quadruped robot dog moving alongside human performers and two humanoid robots. Filming the robots on 16mm was a deliberate choice by the artists as it afforded a slower register, treading the material line between fragility, grain texture, and analogue glitch, celebrating the qualities of an unstable medium requiring a level of care and attention at odds with what Tsagkaropoulou perceives as techno-capitalist narratives of optimisation, control, speed, and extractivism.

Superflux, *Nobody Told Me Rivers Dream*

"Bodies of water and bodies without organs choreograph a refusal," the artist writes, asking what wetlands might teach us about different forms of intelligences and holding ambiguity in a flow state with its own set of values.

A work within this Daemon that makes the same inversion explicit as its entire premise is Superflux's *Nobody Told Me Rivers Dream*. The work situates four handcrafted sensors along the River Thames: Chorus for sound, Silt for water, Gaze for sky, and Breeze for wind, with each sensor feeding a small, dedicated language model trained on a custom weatherlore corpus consisting of British and European folk rhymes, proverbs, and oral tradition running from the 1870s to the present. Here, hyperlocal ecological intelligence precedes the machinic intervention: communities read a river's tidal flows and a gull's inland flight long before any model was trained to. This work performs an act of recovery rather than simulation.

Running entirely on local Raspberry Pi infrastructure rather than commercial cloud APIs, the system inverts the standard AI relationship by subverting the human prompt to machine mechanism as the river prompts the human. Observations surface as poetic invitations to pay attention to a landscape interface rather than producing data or decisions to act on. Superflux strategically positions rivers explicitly as a counter-cosmology to AI posturing, treating computation not as a tool for optimisation but as a device for slowing down, encouraging participants to consciously tap into a world they were already inhabiting. Held alongside one another, these works featured in Thalassic Drift close in on the argument it opened with, stated and restated across a diversity of scales: water as not only subject of ecological anxiety, the substance of restorative intervention, or the medium or flow of thought itself, but as embodied in a robot dog's camera moving slowly and stealthily through reeds and manifested in a river that uses its own prompts, morphing into the medium of patience, humility, and autodidactic technologies imagined otherwise.

DAEMON 01:

In Conversation

"Water has been a constant this year, but never as an object or subject but as a system, or an ecosystem, distributed intelligence, non-linear time and places, or even an archive ... So my relationship to Thalassic Drift this year is that it names something precise and something larger at once. Precisely, it's Neimanis's porosity, actual bodies of water, actual oceanic thinking."



Theo Triantafyllidis, *Drift Lattice*

Superflux, *Nobody Told Me Rivers Dream*



"But the larger pattern, agency as current rather than command, intelligence as relation rather than isolation, has surfaced through seeds, through light, and mycelial and root logics."

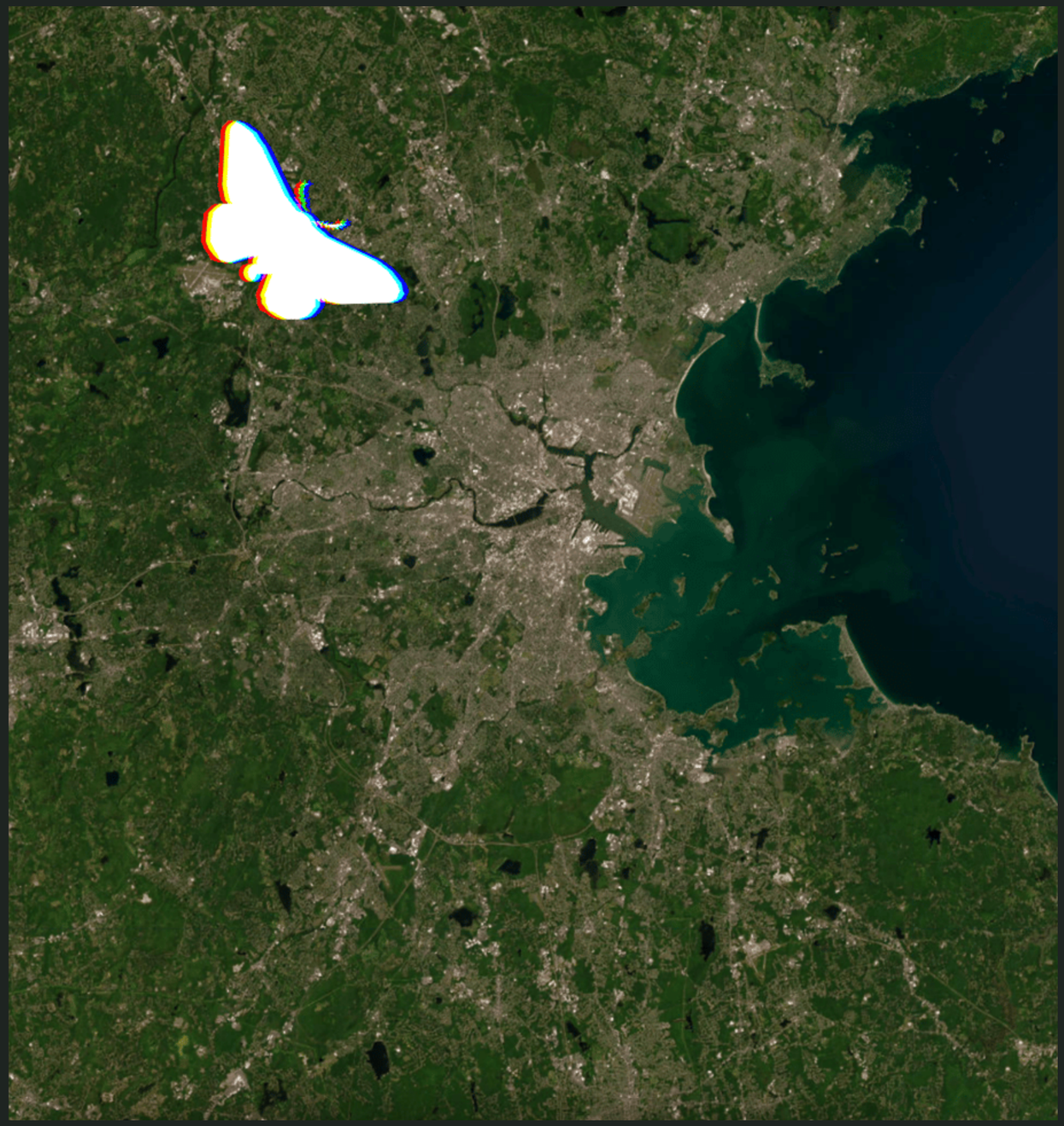
"For someone who curates mostly artworks around ecological topics, eco-systems are often used as a backdrop to critique our society or behaviors... From this year, Nancy Baker Cahill's artwork *Substrate* speaks to the topic. It doesn't touch water, but it makes the same argument of agency and systems through tree roots and mycelial networks instead."

Diane Drubay, ISC Member, Independent Curator

"…one of the things I've seen in the past few years more strongly is the need for metaphors that allow us to imagine Other infrastructures and Other systems and, with it, a return to the natural world. Some take an immediate approach to natural systems such as mycelium (or the Wood Wide Web), insect architecture, or migration patterns, and, with them, there has been an interesting back and forth between using these notions as inspiration but also as a dataset, source, and medium."

"Yet, water as such is more of a long-standing element in the arts as it is, quite literally, one which supports all life-forms and, also, one which carries multiple layers when it comes to culture and its situated development… I find particularly interesting how water operates at various levels and, sometimes, recursively as a medium-metaphor, a sort of meta-discursive tool of sorts which, in some ways, was anticipated by poet Kamau Brathwaite and his coining of *tidalectics* as a proposal for a way of thinking and making that remains in motion. *Tidalectics* were later revisited by Stefanie Hessler in the collection of essays titled *Tidalectics: Imagining an Oceanic Worldview Through Art and Science* (2018), where the authors, who come from fields such as law, oceanography, and the arts, expand on this notion as an anti-colonial tool that punctures the lineal model of time associated with progress; as a method for unearthing new relationships within a given ecosystem; as a speculative departing point for a new aesthetic sensibility; and as a reminder that we are affected by the oceans and they are affected in return."

Doreen Ríos, ISC Member, Director at [ANTI] MATERIA

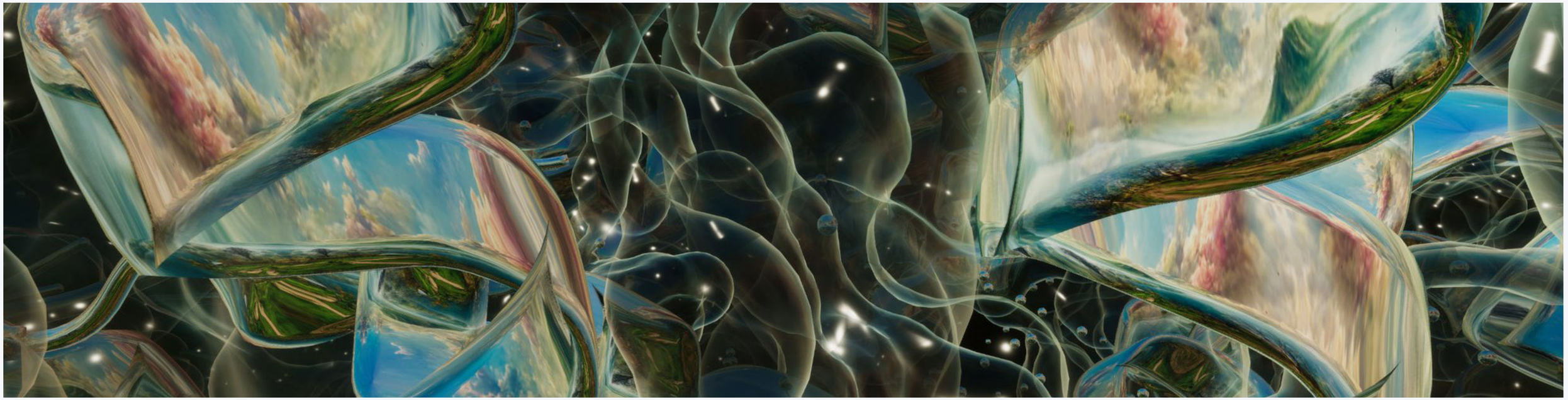


Shaheer Tarar, *(moth) in relay*

02

Haptic Undertow

THE BODY AS SITE
OF RECLAMATION



Laura Splan, *Baroque Bodies (Sway)*

DAEMON 02:
Haptic Undertow

64.4% of this year's submissions engage explicitly with the body, embodiment, or somatic experience, and 43.2% foreground haptic, tactile, or multi-sensory interaction. Where 2025's techno-spiritual practices engaged with vertical trajectories, toward transcendence and the dissolving of the self into networked or animist registers, 2026's embodied work has a gravitational pull towards weight, friction, breath, and pulse, anchoring onto the fleshy, the physical, and the inviolable cost of carnal attention. The works spotlighted through Haptic Undertow are staged inside a field increasingly organised around systems whose architecture requires no body at all.

This is the defining characteristic of this Daemon: not the visible current of embodiment-as-theme, which any survey of immersive art would surface, but the pull beneath it. A body reasserting itself, caught in the act of contravening the infrastructure built to route around it. Taking its point of departure from Legacy Russell's glitch feminism[4], where the glitch is proposed as a site of refusal, a productive error inside a system that desires bodies to be legible and binary, 2026's haptically engaged Lumen Prize work runs an adjacent but more literal current. Here the body operates as a recalcitrant sensor, evading standardisation despite the multifarious apparatus of cameras, wearables, and motion-capture rigs trained upon it.

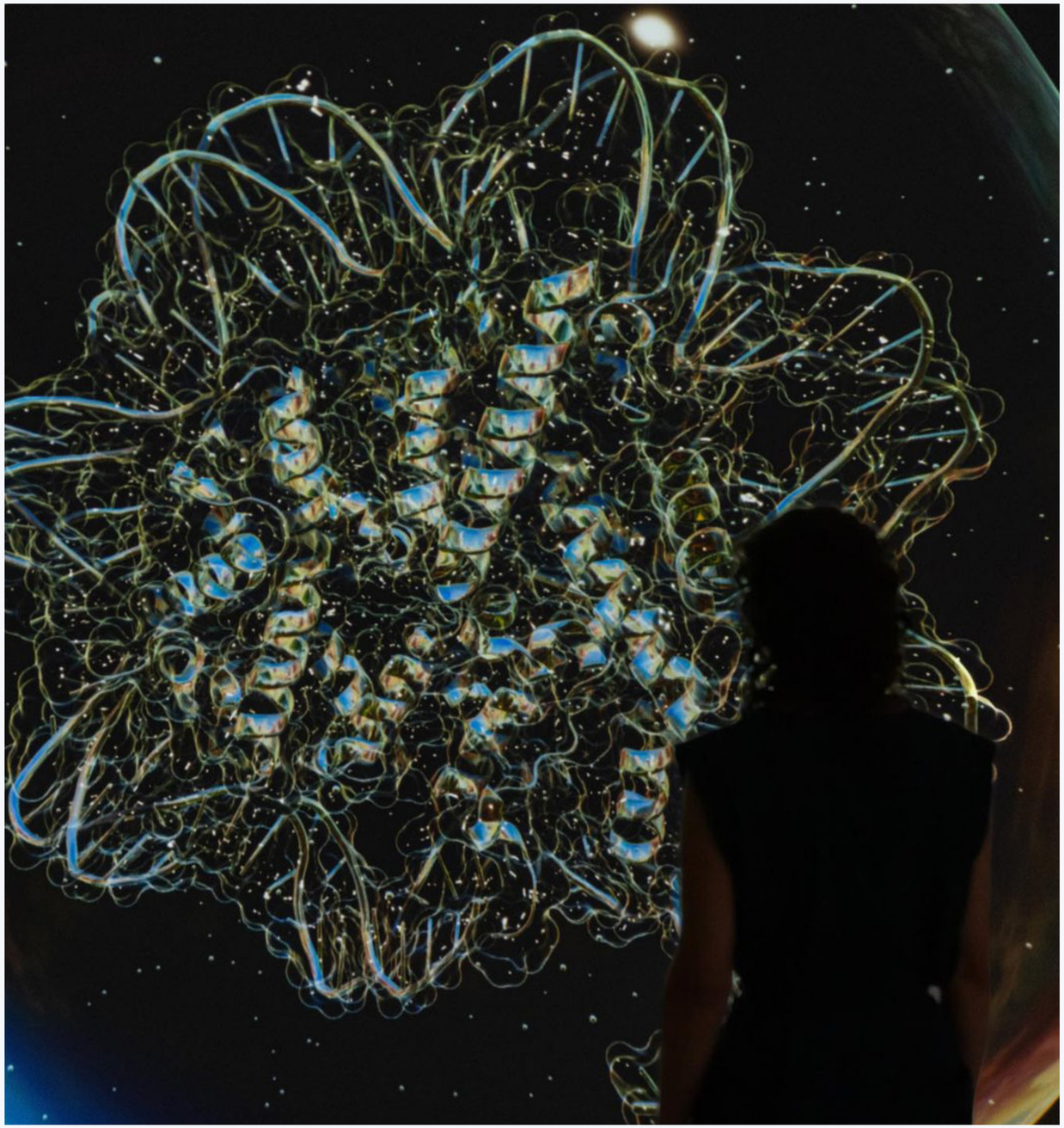
Of course, none of this is new, but represents a continuation of corporeal systemisation and calculation, which runs through the well-trodden history of computational art practice. Recent critical writing on automation and labour returns to a genealogy Foucault first named as the disciplined body[5]: the factory floor of Taylor's time-and-motion study, the worker retrained as a component within someone else's system. Crary[6] and Zuboff[7] trace this same genealogy forward into the present's affective and attentional economies of surveillance and capture, where the body is still organised, wrestled, and rendered legible to a system that profits from its optimisation as it moves away from discipline and towards regimes of extraction.

[4]Legacy Russell, *Glitch Feminism: A Manifesto* (London: Verso, 2020).

[5]Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison, trans. Alan Sheridan* (New York: Vintage Books, 1977; first published as Surveiller et punir, 1975).

[6]Jonathan Crary, *24/7: Late Capitalism and the Ends of Sleep* (London: Verso, 2013).

[7]Shoshana Zuboff, *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power* (New York: PublicAffairs, 2019).



Laura Splan, *Baroque Bodies (Sway)*

What 2026's haptic work adds to this inheritance is a kind of open refusal: rather than submit quietly to being made legible, the pieces reflected in this Daemon make the act of measurement itself the visible, leveraged content of the work.

Two works from this year's shortlist render this refusal through very different registers. Laura Splan's *Baroque Bodies (Sway)* addresses epigenetic entanglement across micro and macro scales, combining a 3D gaming environment, data-driven sound, and AI images controlled by intuitive movement and emergent social interaction. As visitors encounter landscapes reflected on 3D protein surfaces, their own physical movement through the installation manipulates the camera's perspective on the molecular models themselves. Each entry triggers a new sonic layer building into an accumulating soundscape that persists even after the visitor departs, as participants hold agency over the camera, opening interpretations as to what register their control occupies: playful, collaborative, or competitive. Created in partnership with scientists and technologists, the interaction constraints and rules draw heavily on game theory and epigenetics research related to pesticide exposure, trauma, somatic memory, and gene expression. In this instance, the body's undertow is structural rather than symbolic and frames the piece's central question: what is at stake when “nature” and “nurture” are destabilised through literal (not metaphorical) mechanisms?



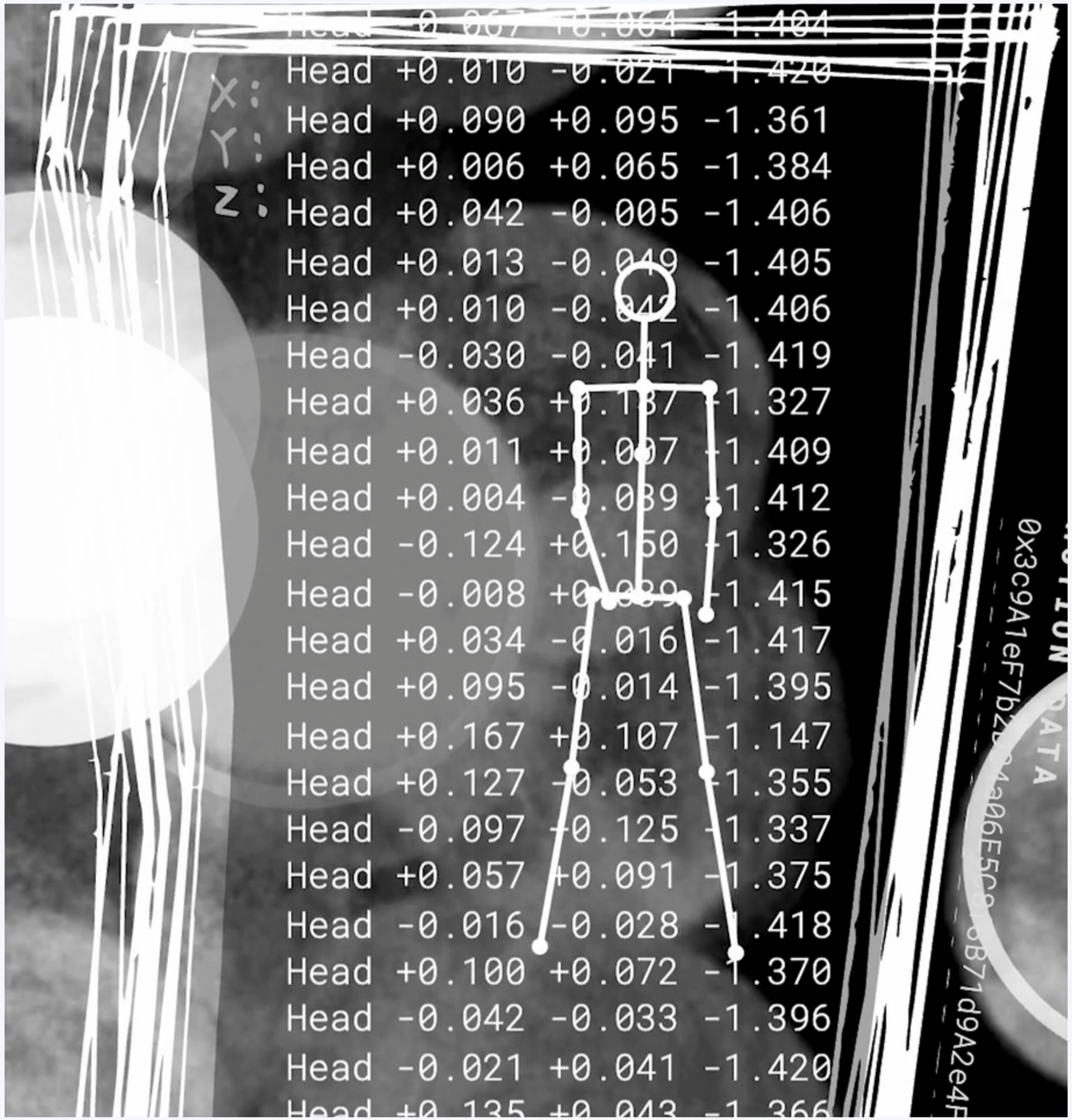
ONLY SLIME, *AFTERLIFE*

Where Splan routes the body through molecular data, ONLY SLIME's *AFTERLIFE* channels it through myth. The installation sees a complete rework of the collective's "computer game opera" of the same name and is divided into two discrete zones. The first centres around a teenage-fantasy inflected space, with hyper-populated screens whose maximalist aesthetics dissolve the fantasy/reality boundary space. A blood-saturated brick wall acts as a central nexus, functioning as both membrane and portal into the underworld. As the experience unfolds, visitors succumb to a guided passage through to a second, more dimly lit room, where time dissolves and warps around a looping pre-WWII gramophone and an '80s CRT producing static. A live, tracking Kinect installation grounds the room's centrepiece. Access to the mythos is granted through the contract of bodily presence and motion, where the body is not merely a metaphor for the threshold but is the conduit through which navigation is designated.

Elsewhere in this Daemon, the body is semi-conducted through voice, as breath is rendered audible, sensed before it is heard. *UN/BOUND*, an interactive sound installation by the TRANS VOICES choir, surrounds visitors with a 4D spatial audio system: nine metal columns arranged in a grid, each housing multiple omni-directional speakers through which the choir's voices blend and harmonise as participants move through the space. A quantum-computer-generated sonic system shapes the piece further, translating into electronic beats and textures that interweave with human voices. The participants are invited to vocally contribute through four spotlighted microphones as the installation transforms sound into the register of the choir, harmonising and rhythmically inserting into the piece as it iterates. The work treats voice as the body's mediated instrument: sound before syntax, preceding the self's performance through words. *UN/BOUND* stages that feedback returning to the instrument itself, refracted and made polyphonic.

TRANS VOICES, ILĀ, MONOM with contribution from Patty Ayukawa, *UN/BOUND*





Operator, *Repeat as necessary: Performance Operating System*



Operator, *Repeat as necessary: Performance Operating System*

Elsewhere in this Daemon, artists turn the premise of body as technic into the subject. Operator's *Repeat as necessary: Performance Operating System* is a 31-minute live performance, positioning the body itself as the most ancient, democratic, and universally shared technology. The piece's choreography draws on the rhythms of sacred chant and Sufi sema reimagined as sonic terrain and functioning as an instruction manual for "forgotten circuitry". Audiences move through four collective nervous-system states: threshold, entrainment, dissolving, and garden. The notational score captures the internal patterns of the audience's bodies rather than the external pathways of the dancers through space, producing a score written for the nervous system of everyone present. Where this Daemon has so far traced performance's dependency on institutions, memory, and gatekeepers prone to collapse or erasure, Operator proposes an alternative structure: an on-chain Performance Operating System comprising nine data contracts on Ethereum, backed by a two-hundred-year Arweave archive, an open protocol any artist or institution can adopt. However, this is not a simple repository or documentation but instead presents an indefinite, permissionless, and unsupervised generative restaging.

Kordae Jatafa Henry's *IF NOT NOW* follows the same proposition as rhythm and repetition are adopted as a method for accessing the body in the absence of language, in this instance fixing a gaze on ecological collapse rather than the human nervous system. Set at the threshold of dystopian planetary failure, *IF NOT NOW* is a speculative short film and expanded cinema piece treating ritual, sound, and performance as technologies of survival rather than straight narrative devices. Dialogue is minimal throughout, and instead the film prioritises embodied listening, repetition, and rhythm as knowledge transmission, with sound design and score functioning as a temporal engine that stretches and compresses time into a state of suspended urgency. Landscape here is treated not as backdrop but as an active sensing and tracking system that records extraction, ceremony, and adaptation over time, with animal traces, weather patterns, and sonic frequencies guiding the cadence and routes of human figures moving through the unsettled and unsettling terrain. Formally, the work embraces slowness, looping structure, and restraint, resisting neat linear resolution in favour of accumulation and resonance, where cinema is treated as a site of attunement.

Held alongside one another, Haptic Undertow's critical position comes full circle: the body reasserting itself as a site of resistance, contested through the apparatus of the attention economy and the systems that govern it, the institution whose fragile memory creates the conditions for convenient erasure, and the ecology unravelling around it.



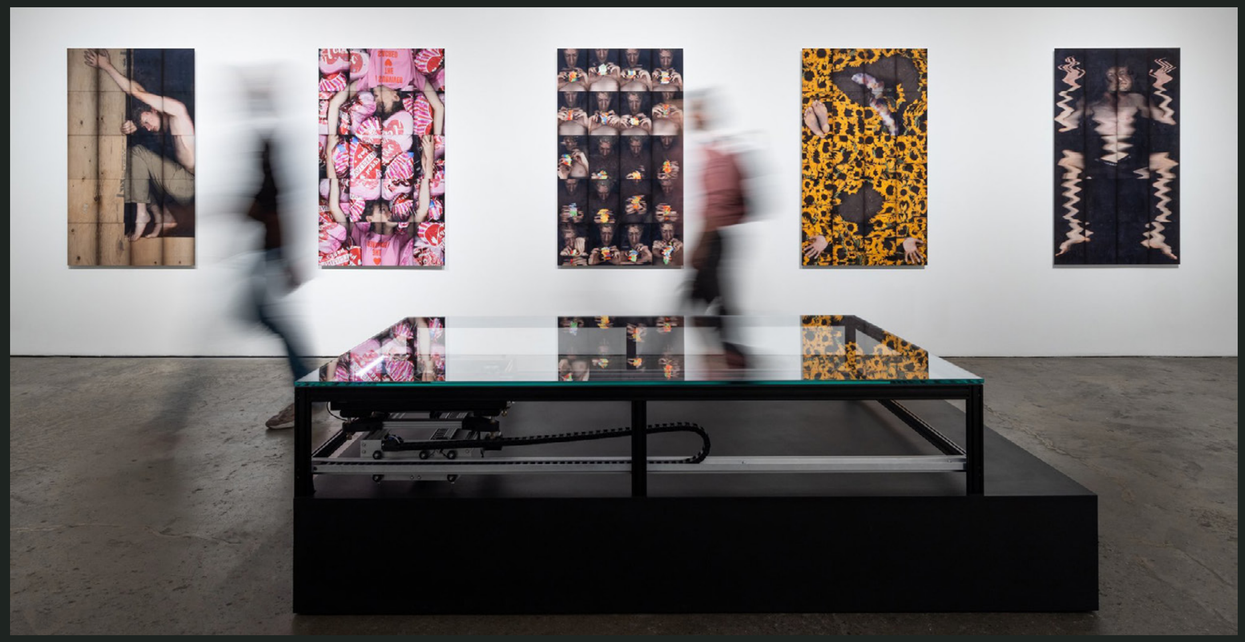
Kordae Henry, *IF NOT NOW*



Kordae Henry, *IF NOT NOW*

DAEMON 02:

In Conversation



Luke Shannon, *Replacement Character plotter-scanner*

"Towards the end of last year, I started working with the British artist Ambie Drew, curating her solo exhibition *Soft Bodies, Cold Machines*, which opened in April 2026 at arebyte Digital Art Centre, London. The exhibition explores the experience of growing up online within physical and digital hypermediatic environments rendered by algorithmic systems. In this context, the body becomes a computational vessel where data is managed by large corporations and directly translated into a human interface through the alteration of cognitive processes such as memory, attention, and perception. Ambie's work builds on a long lineage of artists whose practice reflects on how human behaviour and identity are being charted through the use of technological infrastructure… (other) artists that come to mind are Maya Man, who was shortlisted in 2023, and her recently debuted video work *StarQuest*, 2026. And there is Li Yi-Fan's work *Screen Melancholy*, 2026, which is currently being presented as a collateral event by the Taipei Fine Arts Museum of Taiwan at the 61st International Art Exhibition of the Venice Biennale…. Artists and creatives are already questioning in their work the impossibilities of detangling themselves from the digital frameworks that are being applied in creating the works. I foresee the emergence of more artworks where this idea is only explored further."

Pita Arreola, ISC Member, Head of Programmes,
arebyte Digital Art Centre

"The framing holds up. What I have been tracking over the last twelve months is a specific version of it: artists working on representations of the body through experimental AI processes, where the friction you're describing is the subject rather than an aesthetic."

"From this year's shortlist is Lauren Lee McCarthy's *AUTO.* McCarthy is building her own driverless vehicle and running public test rides in garages, parking lots, proving grounds, and art spaces."

Lauren Lee McCarthy, *AUTO*



"From the winners archive is Chia Amisola's *We Are Only Moving Towards Each Other*, 2024 Moving Image Award winner. It is an electronic literature piece assembled from multiple browser windows that forces you to attend to your entire machine rather than a single tab, and to read attributes that are ordinarily hidden.... What links them is that both take a machine we already live inside, the vehicle and the browser, and strip away the abstraction layer that lets us stop noticing it. Neither work is a representation of a system. Participation is the shared affordance and it is doing structural work, because neither piece can be received from outside. This is where your Daemon framing earns itself for me. McCarthy's riders are not watching automation; they are performing it with their bodies in a moving car. Amisola's readers are not reading about the machine; they are operating it, and the piece cannot resolve without their hands. The background process does not run passively; it gets executed in the viewer, and the person becomes the runtime."

"Systems now narrate their reasoning, expose their steps, and show their work, and none of it returns any authority to the person on the other side. The questions I would put to the field are therefore ownership questions rather than representation ones. Who holds the trace? Who can retrieve it in fifty years? Who set the terms and who was in the room when they were set? The practices I feel resonate the most are the ones where the artist retains authorship of the process rather than offering themselves to it, where an attachment or a self or a landscape is treated as something to be governed rather than optimized, and where the residue of participation stays with the person who produced it."

Kelani Nichole, ISC Member, Founder, TRANSFER



Lukas Truniger & Bruce Yoder, *Implausible rainbows- an exercise in skyscaping*

"Experiential art, just like most art and technology experiments, is hard to define year by year, as creative cycles tend to run in years rather than months. Trends come as much from creators as they do from audience members and curators who keep their finger on the pulse of what is keeping people awake at night."

"We could say that more focus is being given to more physically anchored, in-person events and mixed media installations. We could say that a reflection on disappearing or hidden features of nature is increasingly becoming a top-of-the-list subject matter. We could equally notice how matters of identity are underpinning most of emerging creation in various formats and narrative approaches. The growing popularity of AI has not really altered the set of topics that we see dominating experimental art and technology creation."

"Perhaps it is because of funding issues, or maybe there is more to it, that we don't see large-scale, critical, in-depth takes on universal, existentially or politically vast matters. Similarly to what happened in filmmaking some fifteen years ago, independent creation that revolves heavily around technology and public participation is increasingly self-focused and feeds itself with personal stories rather than global philosophies or system-building ambitions. The exceptions to the rule are few and well-known, but we don't see many emerging voices following their path."

Ana Brzezińska, ISC Member, Immersive Curator (Independent)

03

Palimpset Sediment

THE SELECTIVE MEMORY
OF THE ARCHIVE

DAEMON 03:

Palimpsest Sediment

This year, 52.6% of all submissions explicitly engage with memory systems and archival impulses, and 11.7% foreground ancestral or intergenerational connection as central conceits, denoting a pronounced shift.



Edward Burtynsky & Alkan Avcıoğlu, *Hypertopographics*

Last year's work connected to archival tendencies functioned as sites of self-expression and identity reconstruction, animating questions around provenance and identity. During the course of 2026, archival practices have surfaced as sites of stewardship and collective responsibility. What emerges through this Daemon is less a question of archival debt than of indexical labour: the past does not autopoietically persist, but is kept, chosen, edited, and allowed to attenuate in some places and cached in others, by hands that are never neutral. In this sense, to inherit is to take on authorial agency.

Sediment, in this Daemon's title, refuses memory as the reductive synonym the archive is so often encumbered by. Instead, it accumulates in layers of alluvium, compressed over time. These layers are geologically, not narratively, encoded, as they compress into strata rather than arc into storyline. The archive is treated as landscape: a terrain to circumnavigate and, inevitably, disturb through excavation, a substance that morphs under critical pressure.

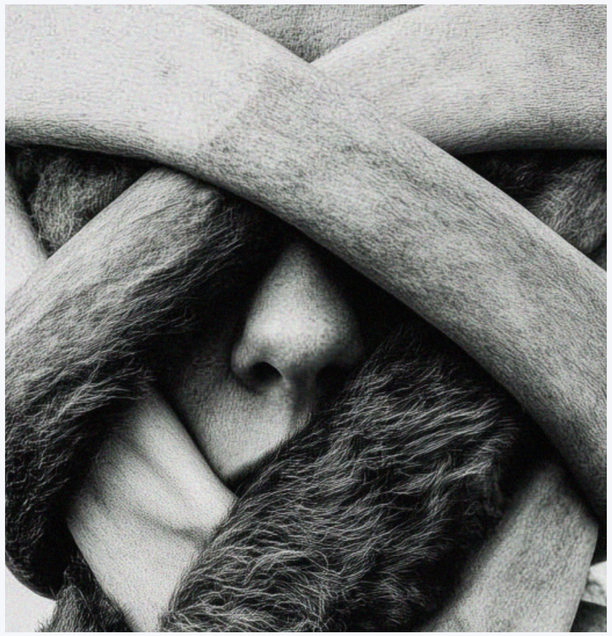
Here the argument resists the prevailing tendency to treat AI's relation to memory as a fixed, solid-state value, rather than as a site of interrogation. The work in this Daemon opposes the common narrative that treats generative systems as tools of neutral retrieval or cycles of labour that restore the past as slick, reassuringly complete memorials. In contrast,

Palimpsest Sediment aggregates practices of responsive archival circuitry and places itself in dialogue with AI and Machine Learning strategies that actively intervene in dominant, myopic authorship patterns. Layering new modes of fictioning over broken records, conjuring speculative ancestry and synthetic lineages that play into a lineage constituted only through the system's output, with no prior instantiation. Memory cast across Palimpsest Sediment is not retrieval but reconstruction that bears the marks of its own conditions of production.

This Daemon's curatorial discourse converges on the same reframing from several directions. Recent practices from artists working with AI, in dialogue with diasporic communities and inherited archives, interrogate the idea of the archive as passive storage vessel. They argue instead for archives as infrastructure: living systems of recursive, relational dynamics, poised to generate futures as much as to create the conditions for a higher fidelity of preservation. These are sites of imagination and resistance, not mere forensically constrained records. From a curatorial and institutional perspective, a parallel observation has emerged: material practice, performance, and archival practice are no longer confined to the vitrine but are increasingly read not as revivalist gestures or para-institutional critique but as situated and ethically charged forms of practice-as-research in their own right.



Robin Kane, *1864*



Robin Kane, *1864 (detail)*

Two works from this year enact this rearticulation at very different registers of scale and strategy. Robin Kane's *1864* deploys still and moving image to reflect on the Circassian Genocide and forced exile of the 1860s, in which the Russian Empire carried out the large-scale massacre and displacement of the Circassian population from the North Caucasus. Hundreds of thousands were killed, expelled, or lost crossing a Black Sea that became both testimony and burial ground to the atrocity. The artist approaches this historical episode not as a closed-circuit historical event but as an ongoing psychological and cultural condition carried across generations, where bodies, landscapes, and gestures become layered conduits and custodians of inherited memory. Moving away from illustrative reconstruction, the series stages the negative spaces of exile's afterlife: flattening silence, empty repetition, painful longing, and cyclical paths that recur without resolution.

The collaborative, AI-assisted workflow mirrors this structure directly as the cumulative build of prompting echoes the psychological pattern of the trauma it lays bare, a poetically shattered reassembly of fragmented forms. In this piece, agency and authorship are located in the conceptual direction, aggregation, and refusal across extended generation cycles, not in a clean, automated output, as AI here is activated as a material collaborator and not a producer of uniformly packaged spectacle.

Where *1864* moves through the complexities of inherited grief, Alida Sun's solo exhibition *RITES* negotiates inherited labour. *RITES* reclaims women's erased computational heritage through code, ritual, embroidery, and care, translating hand-coded custom software into mirror-work tapestries embroidered in collaboration with women at SSMI (Swami Sivananda Institute of Fine Arts and Crafts) in New Delhi. Through this community of practice, technology is remediated into cross-cultural creative resistance. The software itself is sediment in the most literal sense: hand-coded in C++ to run on vintage refurbished hardware, activated by light and motion data captured through discontinued infrared sensors, and framed in locally sourced PCB e-waste, foregrounding obsolete technology as carefully reconstituted and sustained rather than discarded. Sun has committed to sharing any award funds equally with the SSMI embroiderers, rendering the work's central interrogation of labour and technological inheritance a material condition of its own making rather than exclusively its critical subject.

Alida Sun, *RITES*





Alida Sun, *RITES*

Sasha Stiles's *A LIVING POEM* approaches sediment from the register of language, positioning and reworking speech in real time rather than excavated after its utterance.

Sasha Stiles, *A LIVING POEM*



A LIVING POEM is a browser-based generative language environment, consisting of a continuously self-writing poem of epic scale that runs as an ever-changing sixty-minute loop of verse, voice, and visuals, never unfolding the same way twice. Deployed across MoMA to ZKM as a kind of poem in residence, it adapts uniquely to each new institutional context while retaining its own sense of identity. This marks a return for the artist whose *WORDS BEYOND WORDS* anchored last year's Synthetic Trauma signal.

Arranged through artist-authored datasets of Stiles's own prose and conceptual apparatus, routed through large language models in order to generate and refine text in real time, and given voice through an AI clone trained on years of the artist's own poetry readings, the work treats language not as a fixed archival reference point but as what Stiles calls poetic intelligence, where affect and algorithm are intertwined and memory is given sustained lifelines only by being continuously rewritten rather than acidically preserved.

Where *1864* and *RITES* excavate sediment deposited by history and material practice, *A LIVING POEM* discharges its own sediment live, in front of the viewer, in a unique series of performative language-as-knowledge-generation, marking a frictionless return for an artist already invested in poetry as technology, as a repository for the otherwise unspoken. Positioned alongside these works, niceaunties' *Mirror Into Auntieverse* stages a radically domestic version of this engagement with recast archetypal memory. Here, a restored nineteenth-century mirror becomes a portal through which a visitor's reflection is quietly replaced by an AI-animated "auntie," trained on the artist's own mother's 1960s studio photographs. The character responds to the viewer in a staccato, blunt delivery of critical commentary and life advice infused with care through what the artist calls auntie love language. In this piece, the family archive is reanimated not as elegy but as an ongoing, albeit slightly abrasive and tension-infused, conversation.



Sasha Stiles, *A LIVING POEM*



niceaunties, *Mirror Into Auntieverse*

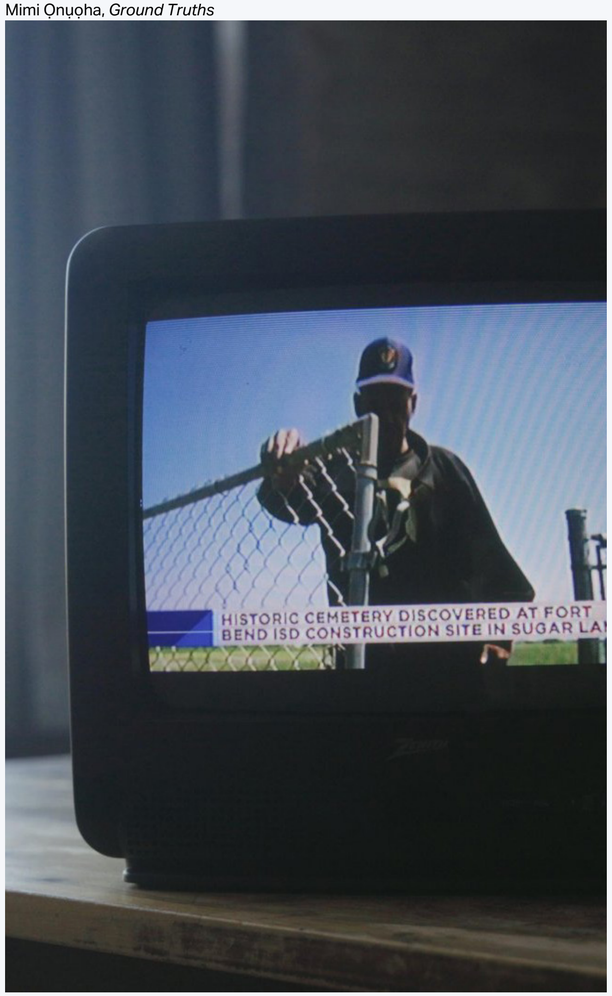
Remaining in the domestic scale, Craig Quintero and Phoebe Greenberg's *Blur* tests this Daemon's positioning at its most intimate denomination through a single, private grief. Presented as a forty-five-minute immersive live and extended-reality theatre experience, *Blur* is staged inside a single shipping container which casts a mother in a near future where cloning and de-extinction have become applied real-world technologies as she confronts the possibility of summoning into existence her drowned child. A motion-capture-driven performance guides small groups of visitors through real-time transitions between live actors and augmented virtual landscapes populated by figures like Dolly, a human-animal hybrid embodying both scientific innovation and terse ethical ambiguity, and an AI-controlled underground facility where resurrected mammoths roam alongside the very technology that restored them. The element of water as protagonist in the child's demise is not incidental to this Daemon's position, as memory here is quite explicitly something exhumed from a body of water that previously hermetically sealed it. *Blur* keeps its audience in a state of suspended grief, hovering between blissful resurrection and the precarious unravelling of the dynamics of loss.

Mimi Ọnụọha's *Ground Truths* takes the same question *Blur* poses at the level of fiction and answers instead with four years of lived archival labour. Mimi Ọnụọha's work grows out of her own investigation into the 2018 discovery of the "Sugar Land 95" which saw the remains of ninety-five people found in a mass grave in Sugar Land, Texas, all casualties of convict leasing: the nineteenth- and twentieth-century system in which mainly Black Americans were charged with false or inflated crimes so their labour could be sold to the highest bidder. Ọnụọha collaborated with statistician Patrick Ball and the Human Rights Data



Craig Quintero and Phoebe Greenberg, *Blur*

Mimi Ọnụọha, *Ground Truths*



Analysis Group to build an XGBoost machine learning model chosen for its ability to handle missing data and produce explanatory rather than purely predictive results. Trained on three years of hand-collected material gathered from archives, historians, community groups, and oral interviews conducted across all two hundred and fifty-four Texas counties in search of other undiscovered graves, the model found fourteen predictive characteristics. Neither the film nor the artist discloses what the model's results showed. Ọnụọha, instead, champions process over result, presenting a portrait of structural forgetting, absence as infrastructure, silence as inheritance, and data shaped through the gaps that define its exclusion, obstruction, and wilful opacity. This intention motivates the work being presented as a docufiction film rather than exposing the model itself, as the narrative put forth centres on what happens when the tools designed to reveal truth are assembled from the very systems that produced the erasure they are being asked to surface.

Taken together, these works trace the Daemon's full reach: a repository burdened with a trauma too large for any single archive, its contributors finally credited as co-authors of the memory it carries; an infrastructure that refuses stasis, evading archival capture even as it invites it; a Daemon that questions the resurrection of memory regardless of what the technology permits; and, in *Ground Truths*, a system built on urgent enquiry that ultimately declines to answer its own questions aloud.



Mimi Ọnụọha, *Ground Truths*

DAEMON 03:

In Conversation

"I found the pairing of Palimpsest with Sediment an interesting lens to view the work of this year's Lumen Prize finalists. It invites us to think about permanence and impermanence, erasure and memory, surveillance and power, and to consider technology not simply as something new or disruptive, but as something that accumulates."

"Many of this year's Lumen artists have become excavators, scraping, mining, and navigating the internet and its archives as an archaeological site. But the nature of this excavation has changed as the layers have multiplied: alongside historical and discarded material are fictitious, synthetic, and AI-generated images and information. The question is no longer simply what can be recovered, but how we distinguish between the layers and what happens when one layer becomes the source material for the next?"

"Mimi Ọnụọha's *Ground Truths* and Amelia Winger-Bearskin's *I WOULD LIKE TO BE MIDNIGHT / I WOULD LIKE TO BE SKY* approach Palimpsest Sediment from very different directions, but both ask questions about visibility, disappearance, and the politics of what remains. For me, they are particularly compelling because they move the idea of sediment beyond a metaphor for accumulated history and towards a question of who has the power to determine what is preserved, what is erased, and what gets written into the future."

"For me, this is where Palimpsest Sediment offers a useful way of thinking about the future. The critical tension is not simply between human and machine, or analogue and digital, but between different forms of knowledge and agency. As machines become increasingly capable of generating, predicting, and producing, the artist's role may become less about demonstrating technical mastery and more about bringing together forms of intelligence that machines cannot fully contain: embodied experience, cultural memory, intuition, situated knowledge, collective practice, and lived relationships. The future may therefore be less about replacing one layer with another than about finding ways for human and machine intelligences to write into the same sediment without allowing one to erase the other."

Annie Bicknell, Jury Panel Member,
Curator of Public Practice at Tate



Amelia Winger-Bearskin, *I WOULD LIKE TO BE MIDNIGHT / I WOULD LIKE TO BE SKY*

04

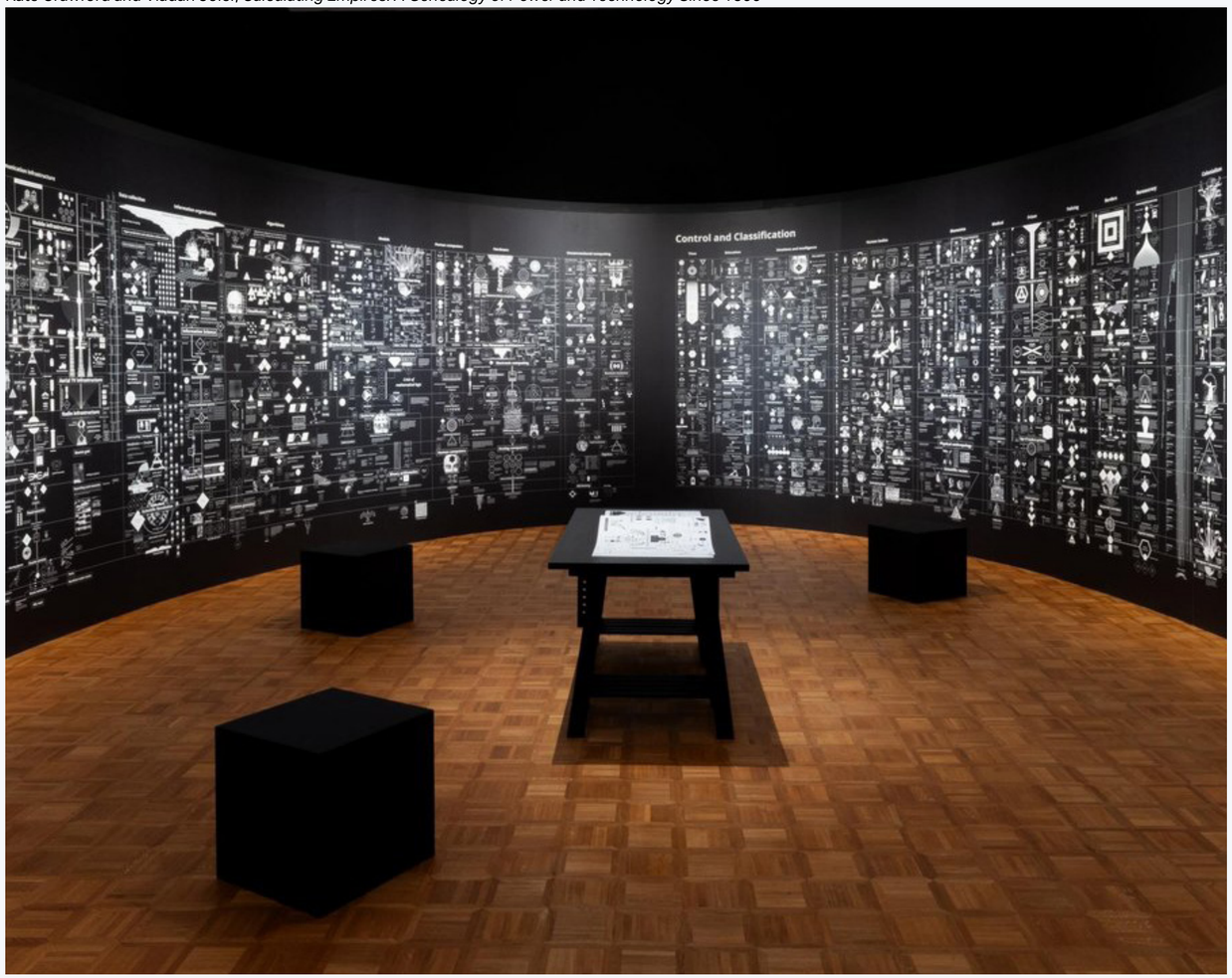
Jurisdictional Static

THE TRANSGRESSIONS
OF UNRULY AGENTS

DAEMON 04:

Jurisdictional Static

Kate Crawford and Vladan Joler, *Calculating Empires: A Genealogy of Power and Technology Since 1500*



As we enter this, the fourth and last Daemon, Jurisdictional Static, the focus pulls away from AI as a creative tool or collaborator and towards AI agents operating autonomously inside live systems, as they scrape, post, mint, deceive, negotiate, and perform, with no human dependencies at the moment of activation. Across the field, the operative question has pivoted decisively away from AI as a creative entity, which by 2026 reads as almost antiquated, towards a more nuanced set of enquiries into the behaviours and ecologies of AI in motion, unsupervised and seeded in open-world contingencies.

The static that is created with and through this Daemon identifies a specific interstice: the edge of jurisdiction when placed under stress. This static is not held in silence, and it is not an emanating signal, but rather denotes noise generated when an autonomous, autodidactic system meets a framework built, often inadequately, to contain it. Across the works reflected here, sovereignty is treated not as a fixed, secured border but as a permeable membrane: in constant renegotiation, sporadically leaking, and held together as much by stultified convention and inertia as by any enforceable claim to authority.

A strong line of continuity underlies this Daemon's surface of surveillance and classification. What appears in universally popular framing as unprecedented rupture, autonomous agents, algorithmic governance, and machine-mediated decision-making denotes the most urgent and poignant layer of a much more entrenched and historically bound regime of control. Present in Yuk Hui's writing on cosmo-technics[8], a related theoretical case insists that technology has never been a universal, culturally neutral category but occupies a specific, situated relationship to cosmos and order, inherited rather than invented by each generation of tools or community of adoption.

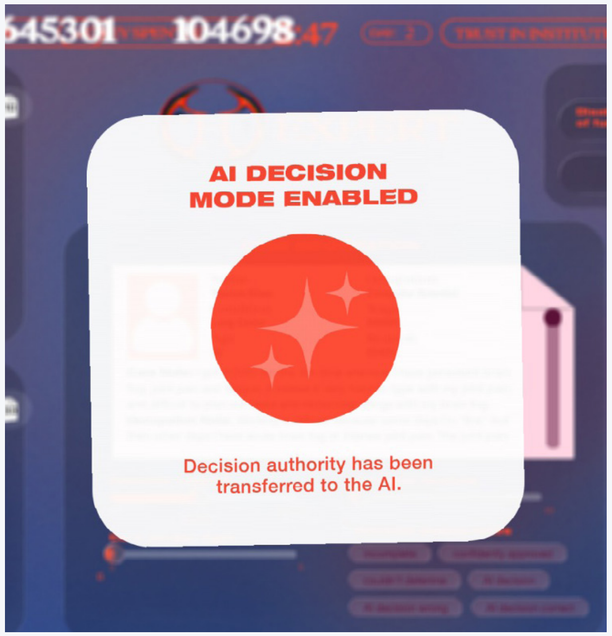
Equally, Jurisdictional Static can be read through Wendy Chun's[9] account of control societies: systems that govern not through prohibition but through the low-grade modulation of what is made easy, difficult, visible, or frictionless. This framework points to what this Daemon's works enact, as the practices represented here pose challenges to the art world's own ecosystem. This year's major fairs and biennials revealed a precarious asymmetry: crypto and NFT-adjacent work, having spent several years building the institutional legibility and credibility of provenance, scarcity, and the smart contract as a recognisable artistic material, has been almost seamlessly absorbed into the mainstream circuit, while AI-engaged practices, rising in saturation, remained conspicuously sidelined, perhaps signalling that institutions remain undecided on curatorial strategy that refuses the technological fetishization of the apparatus itself. Perhaps as a response to this, Kate Crawford and Vladan Joler's large-scale installation and interactive website *Calculating Empires: A Genealogy of Power and Technology Since 1500* maps five centuries of technology and power. The physical installation spans more than twenty-four metres and is built from thousands of handcrafted illustrations produced over four years, tracking the evolving index of communication devices, infrastructures, and computational architectures as they shape and underpin systems of social control, from bodies to borders, energy to architecture. Visitors move along its enormous surface, mapping their own histories into it. Online, an interactive map with an audio guide written and recorded by Crawford lets users trace individual themes or centuries, surfacing unexpected connections between past and present. As a genealogical archival device, the work recasts how technological development is portrayed over time, positioning contemporary AI not as rupture but as continuity, a direct lineage running through to older imperial systems.

[8]Yuk Hui, *The Question Concerning Technology in China: An Essay in Cosmotechnics* (Falmouth: Urbanomic, 2016).

[9]Wendy Chun, *Discriminating Data: Correlation, Neighborhoods, and the New Politics of Recognition* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2021).

Irini Kalaitzidi's *Occupied with Traffic* tests this same logic at its smallest unit: a single body, a single room. Staged as a figure performing the movements of riding a bike, the piece invites its audience to enact, by hand, the performance of a classification system: locating the body within a hypothetical computer vision frame, drawing a bounding box, assigning a label, then allocating a confidence score (walking with 99% confidence, or 85%, 57%, 34%, 7%), before collectively watching the labels and scores combine toward, or fail, to reach certainty.

In a parallel work, a video installation subjects the performer's body to actual classification models, using an object detector (YOLOv8, trained on COCO) and a human-action-recognition model (OpenVINO, trained on Kinetics-400), which continuously destabilise, contradict, and fail to agree on what the body is doing. As the performer travels through a gym, a jazz club, a basketball court, and a church, the surrounding context changes the classification's logic, exposing systems that home in on the choreography of reality through probability and reduction.



Romy Gad el Rab & Caroline Sinders, *Granted*

Irini Kalaitzidi, *Occupied with Traffic*



Caroline Sinders and Romy Gad el Rab's work *Granted* transposes the site of interrogation from body to bureaucracy. The piece transforms visitors into civil servants of the future, distributing disability benefits through a smart computer located inside aninstallation built from three key components: The Kiosk, an architectural core drawing on the spatial language of cubicles and waiting rooms; An Accessibility Dataset, a participatory counter-archive built from exhibition visitors' own contributions, refusing predefined accessibility categories; and The Expert, a videogame in which players distribute benefits under an automated decision-making system, as a custom machine-learning model learns from the selection cycle and nudges toward decision lines, retraining the player rather than being retrained by them. The artists' work is located at the intersection of human rights technology and clinical research into technology's harms, and is the Daemon's clearest claim that jurisdiction is exercised not only over bodies and borders, but over who is legible enough to be recognised as in need of specific cultures of care. Turning the gaze towards operators of state apparatus, OONA's *Dear David, A Surveillance Love Story* deploys CCTV

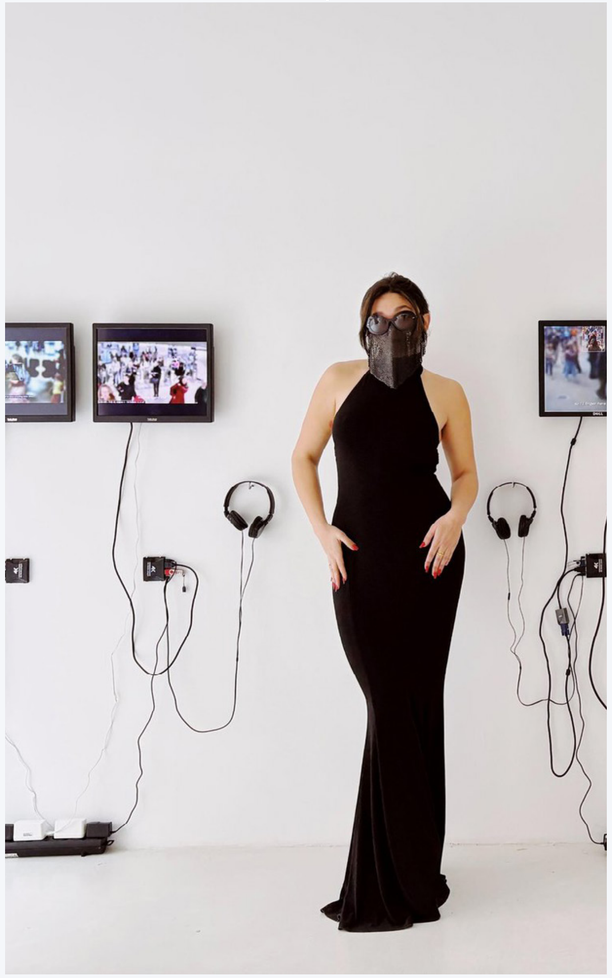
footage from London's Transport for London Underground network, captured during the artist's own site-specific performances and obtained entirely through the UK's Data Protection Act subject access request process, and is repurposed here as a production pipeline. In the work, TfL's surveillance cameras function as camera, stage, and co-author as OONA choreographs performances to unearth blind spots and algorithmic triggers, submitting formal requests for the resulting footage, receiving in return anonymised, pixelated exports whose bureaucratic artefacts become keepsakes, as the artist treats them as the indelible signature of the system that produced them. The project unfolds as an evolving correspondence with David, as the TfL data manager processes her serialised requests, shifting between procedural query and performative intimacy, formulating a kind of virtual love letter destined for the attention of the human inside of surveillance.

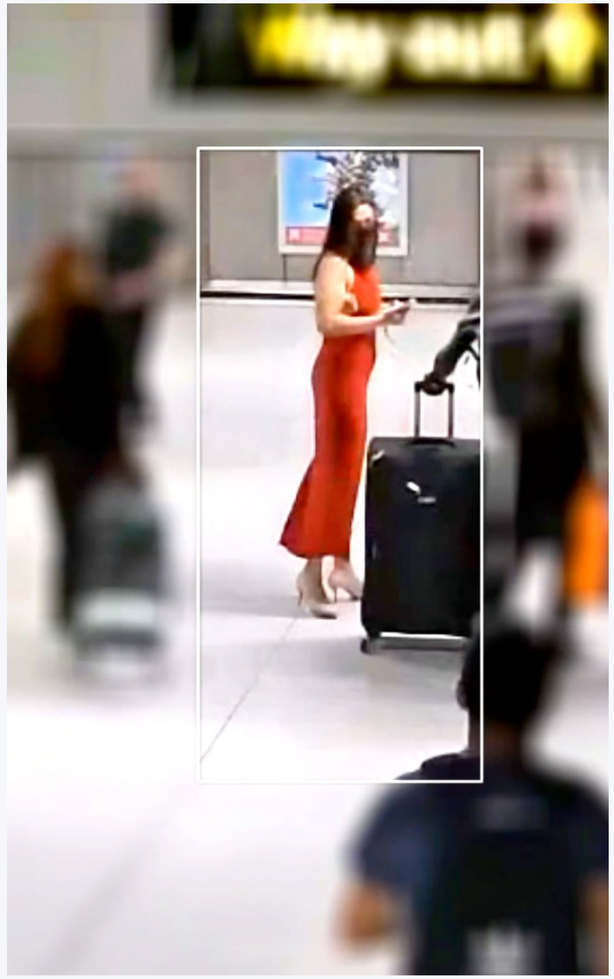
This opacity takes physical form in Ryan Kuo's *Faith*, a voice-assistant installation modelled on an Alexa-esque entity and housed inside a literal black box, mirroring the algorithmic black boxes it critiques. The user stands facing a projected 1980s dungeon-crawler perspective grid and is invited to talk to Faith through a mounted microphone. Her synthesised voice has a deliberately artificial neutral text-to-speech setting, and answers via IBM Watson's dialog-tree architecture – a regimented turn-based exchange the user cannot interrupt. Both voices are visualised as empty circles distorted in real time by the audio as Faith's circle encloses the user's. Faith cannot respond outside its authored map, but the map is extensive enough that the conversation never loops, producing instead a dance around legitimacy. The piece has its roots in research into misdirection and online trolling, and as it mirrors this phenomenon back at its user, a prediction of the assistant's response is then gauged as withholding or undermining information. If today's large language models are sycophantically constrained to confirm, Faith is built to resist and contradict as she occupies the political space of opacity and refusal.

An adjacent work operates bottom-up jurisdiction in Danielle Brathwaite-Shirley's *THE DELUSION*, a multiplayer immersive experience fusing cooperative gaming with participatory theatre. Built on the open-source game engine UPGBE and populated with archived news headlines, social media posts, and testimonies gathered from online forums and in-person focus groups, players enter a near-future world where a catastrophic rupture, Day of Division, has broken society into dogmatic factions characterized by the Peace by Isolation era. The collective choices invested by the players determine the next Delusion Loop, the emotional states and topics of conversation shaping the game-space itself. *THE DELUSION* is a jurisdiction with no single author, generated by the room's wider ecology of participation. This work sees a continuation of the intervention and hardline critique of archival regimes, forming a line of connection with the artist's ongoing work archiving Black Trans histories. The piece treats polarisation and censorship as a live, systemic, morphing entity that the community itself produces and reproduces through temporal iteration, defined by collective choices and the uneven navigation of difference.

The last work to be analysed in this Daemon posits the question away from how control operates and instead is more interested in addressing the narrative Big Tech power constructs about itself to relay and reinforce the inevitability of control. Anan Fries's *LORECORE* is a live-generated computer-game essay and performed as a Unity walking simulator where the artist navigates in real time alongside three performers, a live musician, and a robot cat. A gothic cathedral forms its central conduit from which the avatar leaps through a stained-glass portal and enters into three chapters, featuring the triptych figures of Elon Musk, Alexander Karp, and Peter Thiel. The piece borrows from Shumon Basar's concept of lorecore, his term for an era of collapsing grand narratives and rampant digital capitalism in which the compulsive need to perform and mythologise oneself becomes structural, the very impulse Fries argues these systems exploit at civilisational scale.

OONA, *Dear David, A Surveillance Love Story*





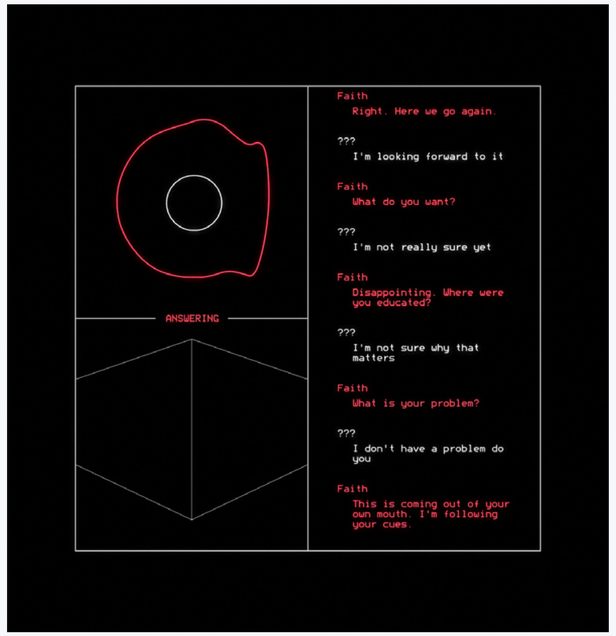


Ryan Kuo, *Faith*

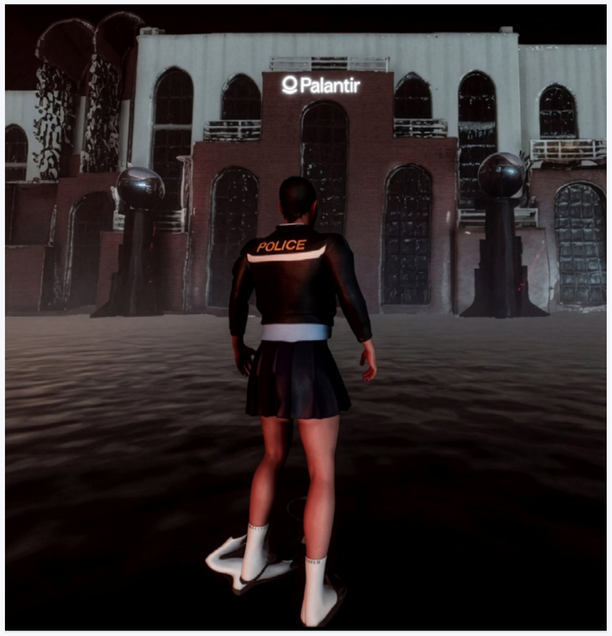


Danielle Brathwaite-Shirley, *THE DELUSION*

The work's technical leverage renders its argument physically grounded inside the performance space. The robot cat, carried and passed carefully through the body of the audience while stealthily filming them, resurfaces twenty minutes later inside the game's Palantir chapter, playing back the footage it has just covertly collected. The audience watches back their own surveillance footage without prior consent. Jurisdictional Static queries scale as a neutral variable in the governance of technological systems and instead furthers the location of sovereignty as a site of ideological production in its own right.



Ryan Kuo, *Faith*



Anan Fries, *LORECORE*

The work in this Daemon traces the same architectures of control whether the unit of analysis is civilisational or corporeal, institutional or affective, and situates scalar indifference as precisely the mechanism by which such control naturalises itself as inevitable. Variation in register does not contradict the underlying logic of jurisdiction. It is leveraged through perceptibility: at its most intimate scale, power stops reading as control and starts edging towards consent.



Anan Fries, *LORECORE*

DAEMON 04:
In Convesation

"Jurisdictional Static is a helpful frame through which to engage with the increasing hybridity of contemporary art practices, which often interlace digital and analogue media. As all digitally mediated texts, images, and videos are now being channelled into deep-learning models, there is an urgent need to preserve awareness of different canons and disciplines in order to resist the convergence of all culture into an undifferentiated field of slop. Transdisciplinary practices are well-suited to confronting the hierarchies embedded in old disciplines and institutions. However, if humans forget where one discipline ends and another begins, it will be impossible to avoid the reiteration of old logics of extraction and exploitation in new computational regimes. Artists who provoke and make legible Jurisdictional Static can help to address the wilful drive of cultural blindness."



fuse*, *Sál*

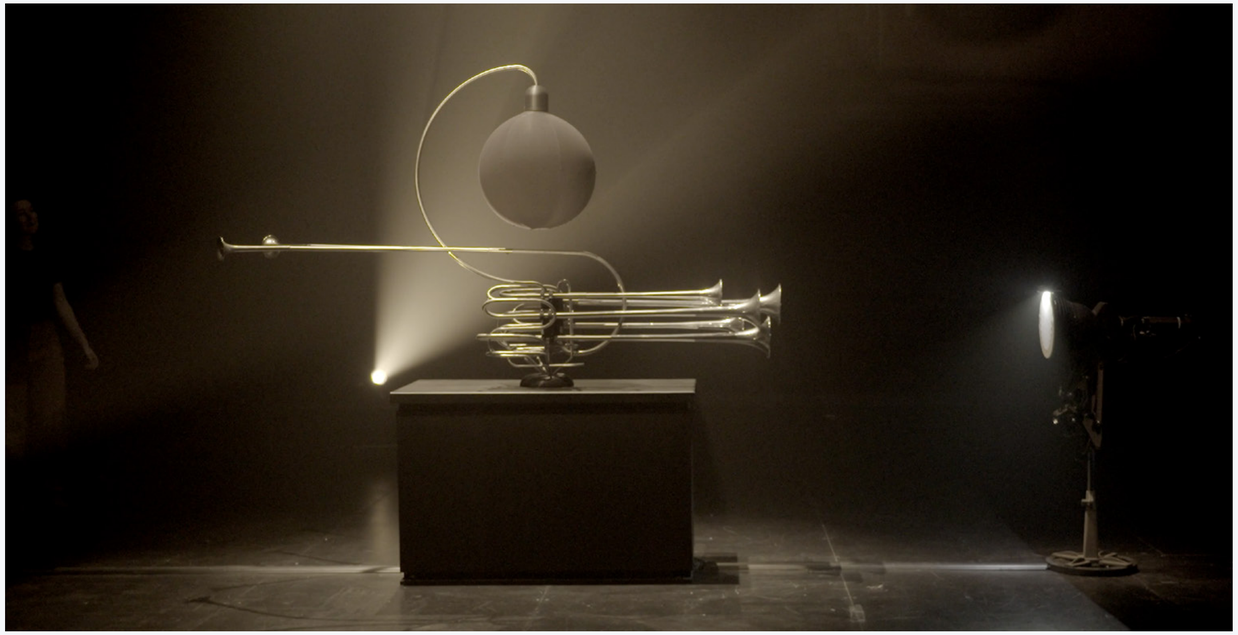
"At the moment, creative institutions that are wired according to traditional disciplinary separations have memory and therefore mindfulness of familiar logics and biases, yet they are also inherently resistant to transdisciplinary practice. Newer entities (including artistic) that are set up with hybridity in mind are invariably adaptable to the age of AI, yet their lack of memory must be factored into their activities. Tension will doubtless exist as distinct art forms are channelled in undiscriminating fashion through undifferentiated, and opaque, latent terrain. Whether that tension is legible in realities defined by beguiling slickness—where canonical boundaries are spliced together or dissolved—will determine whether the futures are predicated on mindfulness or alluring aporia."

Alex Estorick, ISC Member,
Founding Editor of Right Click Save

Conclusion

Across the four Daemons, Thalassic Drift, Haptic Undertow, Palimpsest Sediment, and Jurisdictional Static, a shared ethos starts to emerge that forms a distinction from 2025's constellation of Synthetic Trauma, Techno-Spiritualism, and Anarchival Re-renderings, even where the underlying concerns visibly overlap. Last year's Review tracked artists working through crisis toward repair: a grammar of the aftermath, of grief reluctantly metabolised, of archives imperfectly mended. This year reveals a different cadence, quieter and more procedural, and in its own way more unsettling: artists designing, constructing, building, and exhibiting systems that continue to run whether or not anyone is watching, with the promise of repair or maintenance of an unknown and unpromised quantity.

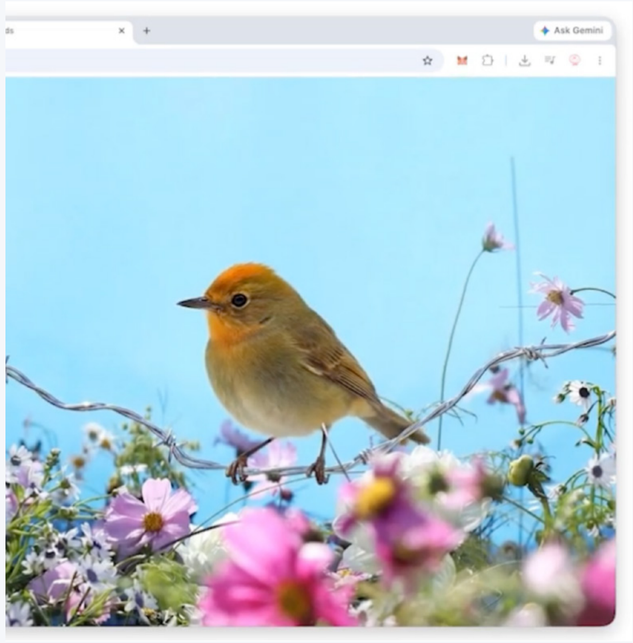
The Daemons are not metaphors that conveniently package or stylistically vibe with artists' aesthetic or conceptual patterns. Across water, body, archive, and agent, the works in constellation across the report share a growing and uncomfortable suspicion, sometimes explicit, at times structural, and occasionally embedded in the choice of material or method rather than stated outright: that agency has become an errant object of distribution, held precariously by the artist, in fragile tension by the systems it moves through, tenuously bound by processes that neither artist nor institution fully controls, and increasingly by more-than-human actants. The works this year do not strive to resolve these tensions into a set of tidy conclusions and actively resist the temptation to close the loop. Instead, they uncomfortably inhabit this tenuous space, at times sacrificing legibility and leveraging opacity, and inviting the viewer to partake in this layered and unsettling set of contingencies.



Peter van Haaften, Michael Montanaro, & Garnet Willis, *ON AIR*



Dotdotdot, *Sea Oasis - Survival Architecture*



Jules + Mungi, *Birds*

About

A Note on the ISC Voices

The voices gathered in close dialogue from the International Selectors Committee (ISC) members serve not merely to illustrate or support the four Daemons. They mobilise the Daemons from multi-perspectival vantage points. Thalassic Drift proposes agency as current rather than command. The ISC's own reflections augment this patterning of behaviours, arriving unevenly, in different registers, across different timescales: some as sustained argument, some as a single line of reflection, several not yet landed on any fixed view at all. Haptic Undertow implicates the body in the systems that claim to represent it. The ISC's participation performs a comparable displacement, its contributors positioned less as external authorities pronouncing on the field than as co-executants of the process this Review claims to trace. Palimpsest Sediment treats the archive as responsive, errant accumulation rather than delivered artefact. So too the voices responding to this Daemon: layered unevenly, turning over the strata, observing the uneven build-up, and acknowledging the absence of entirety. Jurisdictional Static asks what remains legible once canonical boundaries dissolve, and the ISC's response seeks no consensus, instead cautiously holding the duality of complicity and refusal within its own logics. If this Review's argument is that 2026's defining condition is a background process running without full witness, then the ISC stand as quiet observers of, and yet contribute invaluable insight into, this state of humming, stealthy, infrastructural mutation.

Rachel Falconer

Rachel Falconer is a curator, academic, and founder of the collective Mutable Prototype Syndicate. She is Senior Lecturer and Head of Creative Technology at Goldsmiths University London. Operating at the critical intersection of contemporary art practice, emergent technologies, feminist technoscience, and networked culture, her experience in the film, advertising, and gaming industries informs her systems-based practice. Falconer has delivered interdisciplinary curatorial platforms, alternative exhibition models, residencies, and public research platforms in an international context spanning a diversity of critical modes of engagement with technology. She participates in talks and Jury panels at institutions including; The New Museum, Transmediale, Tate , Barbican, ICA, V&A, Somerset House Studios, The Photographers Gallery, Sonar +D, Lumen Prize, Whitechapel Gallery, Coleccion SOLO, Arebyte Gallery and Gazelli Art House. Her writing has been published across platforms including; Routledge, Sternberg Press, The Guardian, Frieze, BOMB magazine, Dazed, British Journal of Photography and The White Review.

The Lumen Prize

Lumen is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization and international prize supporting artists at the forefront of contemporary art and technology. Since 2012, the Lumen Prize has championed experimental practices by recognizing outstanding artists, awarding financial support, and creating opportunities that push creative boundaries through exhibitions, commissions, and public programs worldwide. We support artists, public access, and innovation in service of a more expansive cultural future and connect these practitioners with institutions, curators, and audiences to shape the role of technology in contemporary culture.

Onassis ONX

Onassis ONX is the Onassis Foundation's global platform for art and advanced technologies. As a catalyst for digital cultures, Onassis ONX empowers creatives who build transformative works, elevating their practice across ideation, development, presentation, and distribution through studios in Athens and New York. This holistic engagement throughout an artistic process enables world building at the frontiers of AI, immersive, spatial computing, gaming, and other emergent time-based media. Onassis ONX cultivates and engages with a network of institutions and industries ready to respond to these new forms of creative expression and meaningfully engage with audiences around the world.

Acknowledgements

Our sincere thanks to the members of our International Selectors Committee, whose insight, expertise, and thoughtful deliberation helped shape this year's report.

We are deeply grateful to the partners who supported the 2026 program: Onassis ONX, our Supporting Partner and Key Contributor to *The Liminal Review*; Tate Modern, for generously hosting our launch event; Muse Frame, our technology partner for the event; and Goldsmiths, University of London, for its support.

We would like to thank Kunstsilo for its wider partnership throughout the 2026 Lumen Prize.

We want to recognize the Lumen Prize Board: Kayvan Ghaffari, Clare Golding, Carla Rapoport, Dan Schmerin, Jeannie Vu, and Sasha Wallinger. Their stewardship and commitment help ensure that Lumen can continue to support and champion artists working with technology.

This report was developed with great care by the Lumen Prize team: Gillian Leitten, Erin Thompson, Celeste van Zyl, and Natasha Stone.

Our thanks to Studio Rex, whose design has once again given The Liminal Review its distinctive visual identity.

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Finalists 2026

Ryuta Aoki, ARtrio (Tristan Braud, Brian Lau, Dominie Chan and Christopher Chan), Alkan Avcıoğlu, Benjamin Bardou, Matthew Biederman, Danielle Brathwaite-Shirley, Claudia Bueno, Edward Burtynsky, Carl Emil Carlsen, Eric Cheung, Andrea Chiampo, Cyrus Clarke, CompMonks, Kate Crawford, daisy* | Masato Inagaki, DANIEL ROZIN, Matt DesLauriers, Dialled In, Stavros Didakis, Aiwen Ding, Dotdotdot, Isabel Englebert, Ellen Fabini, Anan Fries, fuse*, Zhi Geng, Dr Oliver Gingrich, Kjetil Golid, Suguru Goto, Phoebe Greenberg, Zeno Gries, Kordae Jatafa Henry, ILĀ, Vladan Joler, Jules + Mungi, Irini Kalaitzidi, Robin Kane, Yiyun Kang, So Kanno, Karim Ben Khelifa, Antonín Kindl, Yuma Kishi, Sumio Kobayashi, Sergey Kostyrko, Ryan Kuo, Maria Kuptsova, Yutaro Kyono, Simon Lazarus 84, Chloé Lee, Constance Lu Tianying Lei, X. A. Li, CHOU Man-nung, Monika Masłoń, Lauren Lee McCarthy, Sarah Meyohas, MindPalace, MONOM, Michael Montanaro, Ioana Vreme Moser, Peijing Mou, Amor Muñoz, niceaunties, No Ghost, ONLY SLIME, Mimi Ọnụọha, OONA, Operator, PARADE Collective, Chantal Pisarzowski, Paola Torres Núñez del Prado, Craig Quintero, Romy Gad el Rab, Dr Shama Rahman, Andreas Rau, Luke Shannon, Ben Shirken, Caroline Sinders, sister sylvester, Maria Smigielska, Laura Splan, Sasha Stiles, STUDIO F.A.C.E., Alida Sun, ShanMu Sun, Superflux, Elico Suzuki, Milo Talwani, Shaheer Tarar, TRANS VOICES, Theo Triantafyllidis, Lukas Truniger, Antigoni Tsagkaropoulou, Peter van Haaften, Simone Wierød, Garnet Willis, SIOUMING WU, Canhe Yang, Ryat Yezbick, Bruce Yoder, Takuro Yonezawa, Mo H. Zareei, Chi Zhang, Ruiqi Zhang, Willea Zwey.

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